

Ukhat al Quran: Divine Mercy and the Quran in the Sahifah al Sajjadiyyah

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Dedication

For my Maula Sajjad, whose life and words are engraved upon my heart and soul

And for my Baba, may you rest in peace, until we meet again, my dearest friend.

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Introduction

The Twelve Shi'ite Imams have made momentous contributions to the Islamic intellectual and mystical tradition. Ali ibn Husayn (d. 95A.H/ 713 A.D), commonly known as 'the Prostrating One' or Al-Sajjad (Sadooq, 33, Al-Qarashi, 18) is the fourth Shi'ite Imam and the author of the first systematic prayer manual in Islam, *Al-Sahifah Al-Sajjadiyyah* (Chittick, Introduction 1988, xv, Al-Qarashi, 378). The prayer manual covers a remarkable breadth of psycho-spiritual, socio-familial, legal and economic human conditions. The *Sahifah* is regarded as an early esoteric Islamic text. It is a mystical book of psalms singing the praises of Divine Unity (*Tawheed*). A book of cosmic anthropology and spiritual psychology that unveils gnostic mysteries and guides believers in engaging with the Divine. Throughout the supplications, Al-Sajjad juxtaposes Divine Nature with human nature and explores various junctures of the one-on-one relationship between a soul and its Creator. In doing so, he creates a blueprint for direct communication with the Infinitely Merciful, which Muslims have followed and benefitted from for over 1400 years. Unlike theological and jurisprudential endeavours, the *Sahifah* exemplifies how devotional literature encapsulates the intimacy, love, and Mercy of the relationship between the Divine and each human being.

However, it is not merely a prayer manual. In light of Al-Sajjad's lofty status as an infallible *wali* and Imam in the esoteric Shi'ite and Sufi traditions, the *Sahifah* must be analysed as a mystical treatise and book of gnostic knowledge, which "expresses the highest aspirations of the Muslim soul" (Chittick, Introduction 1988, xx). Hence, the prayers in the *Sahifah* outline humanity's relationship with Allah, "which could be passed around and become "communal property" (Chittick 1988, xxvii). According to Al-Qarashi, the *Sahifah* is the

"oldest" compendium of supplications (Al-Qarashi, 378). Although the Imams before him have composed many supplications, Al-Sajjad is the first infallible (*masum*) to write and curate his supplications as a systematic book. Before its authorship, the only book with divine origins was the Quran, as the *Nahjul Balaghah* was compiled by al-Sharif al-Radi (d. 359 A.H./1015 A.D.) in the 10th century, three centuries after Ali ibn Abi Talib's death (Shah-Kazemi, 36). The *Sahifah* was written during the life of Al-Sajjad, in the same century that the Quran was revealed. This makes the *Sahifah* the closest to the Quran in terms of divinely inspired authorship and time frame. In the Shi'ite tradition, the words of the Imams are third only to the Quran and *ahadith*. Hence, any book authored by the Twelve Imams is of great spiritual and doctrinal significance.

In the Shi'ite tradition, the *Sahifah* is uniquely attributed as "the sister of the Quran" (*Uzkhat al-Quran*) (S. M. Jafri, ii, Chittick 1988, xviii, Al-Qarashi, 378). The tradition also believes that the Twelve Imams are divinely inspired and vested with 'spiritual authority' (*walayah*), which includes the authority to interpret the Quran correctly. Hence, the *Sahifah's* role as the Quran's sister is not merely honorific or symbolic but functional and necessary in understanding the Quran and through it – Allah's *Tawheed* and Mercy. The attribution is also due to its intimate esoteric relationship with the Quran's thematic concerns, content, language, motifs and imagery. According to William Chittick, a translator of the *Sahifah* in English, "every element of the *Sahifah's* mosaic corresponds to elements of the Quranic text" (Chittick 1988, xli). The attribution also reflects the similarities in the "spiritual attitude expressed in the *Sahifah* and the Quranic statements about Allah and His relationship to His servants" (Chittick 1988, xli). Divine Mercy is the

most predominant spiritual attitude in both these texts, and the *Sahifah* echoes the Quran's overwhelming Mercy.

Thesis statement

This research will briefly outline how the *Sahifah's* mosaic and thematic concerns correspond with the Quranic mosaic in light of Divine Mercy by exploring three aspects of their relationship. The first is the thematic and stylistic correspondence between the mosaic formats of these texts. The paper will also briefly analyse how Divine Nature is portrayed in the *Sahifah* vis a-vis Quranic verses. Lastly, the research will examine how Al-Sajjad perceives the Quran as a mercy from Allah.

Research Methodology and Literature Review

Quantitative data

The research employs quantitative data and qualitative analysis to understand the *Sahifah's* relationship and correspondence to the Quran. Quantitatively, the paper looks at how 319 references and allusions to Quranic verses are placed within the *Sahifah* verses¹. There are 219 direct quotations and 100 allusions to various verses². Out of 319, 257 references and allusions are unique, while other Quranic verses are quoted more than once³.

The paper also looks at the frequency of various Quranic terms, ideas and 'The Most Beautiful Names and Attributes' (*Asma al-Husna wal Siffat*) in the *Sahifah*. The quantitative data is available in Appendix A. The first table categorises supplications by their titles to outline the predominant thematic concerns in the *Sahifah*⁴. The second table categorises the beginning verses of the 84 supplications⁵, while Table 3 looks at their ending verses⁶. The thematic concerns of the first and last verses present the psycho-spiritual and intellectual-emotional state Al-Sajjad wants believers to approach and leave each supplication with. The fourth table records all the Quranic references and allusions in the *Sahifah*, with their frequency of occurrence and the supplications they can be found in.

The paper then categorises Quranic verses into three overarching categories: table 5(a) includes those that relate to Divine Nature as per the *Asma al-Husna wal Siffat*. Table 5(b)

¹ Table 4.

² Table 4.

³ Table 4.

⁴ Table 1.

⁵ Table 2.

⁶ Table 3.

contains verses on human nature, and Table 5(c) has verses relating to miscellaneous themes such as the Day of Judgement, Prophets and the Quran. In her analysis of al-Shirazi's supplication for 'God's Mercy on the Day of Arafa', Tahera Qutbuddin claims that "profuse citation of the Quran, directly or by invoking its themes and vocabulary ... infuses an Islamic flavour into the entirety of the supplication, as well as injecting an air of doctrinal and temporal authority" (Qutbuddin, A Supplication for God's Mercy on the Day of 'Arafa, 512) Hence, paying attention to the placement and involvement of Quranic verses in the *Sahifah* provides a nuanced understanding of the relationship between the two texts.

The sixth table looks at a selection of the predominant aspects of Divine Mercy, such as Allah's Generosity, Pardon and Kindness, amongst others, and records their frequency in the *Sahifah*. Observing the "repetition of keywords, especially the word mercy, and the repetition of key phrases, especially the benediction on the Prophet Muhammad and his progeny, who are the embodiment of God's mercy, drives home the key messages of the supplication" (Qutbuddin, A Supplication for God's Mercy on the Day of 'Arafa, 512) The quantitative analysis aims i) to demonstrate the vast expanse of thematic concerns in the *Sahifah* and ii) to locate and categorise Quranic references and allusions in the text. While this paper is a brief overview of some of these aspects, the data can be used for a deeper analysis of the intricate manner in which Quranic themes, motifs and imageries are weaved throughout the verses of the *Sahifah*.

Qualitative analysis

The quantitative data is supplemented by qualitative research on the *Sahifah* from the Shi'a tradition. Unfortunately, unlike Arabic and Persian, there is a disappointing dearth of scholarship on the text in the English language. However, a few crucial essays and introductory commentaries are available in Western academia, which are imperative for a rudimentary study of the *Sahifah*. Hence, this research will focus solely on resources available in the English language.

The paper uses William Chittick's translation of the *Sahifah* from Arabic to English, titled, '*The Psalms of Islam*'. While there are many translations of the Quran and Chittick uses A.J Arberry's '*The Koran Interpreted*', this research will utilise '*The Study Quran*' translated by Seyyed Hossein Nasr and others. *The study of the Quran* includes a plethora of exegesis, which are also utilised in this research. Since the English translations may sometimes differ – in case of discrepancies between the two regarding the *Asma al-Husna wal Siffat* in the *Sahifah*, this paper has resorted to Arberry's translation vis a vie Chittick. The research chooses not to translate Allah as God since it considers the term beyond translation, and the Divine Name can only be understood in the Islamic Tradition by maintaining its grammatical and lexicographic integrity in Arabic. Mystical, esoteric *ahadith* and *ahadith al-qudsi* have been sourced from Nasr's '*Garden of Truth: The Vision and Promise of Sufism, Islam's Mystical Tradition*'. '*The Garden of Truth*' outlines the most essential aspects of Islamic spirituality for modern audiences. This paper looks at the *Sahifah*, the Quran, the *ahadith* and the sayings of the Twelve Imams as primary sources.

Several commentaries and lexicographic manuals on the *Sahifah* exist in the Shi'ite tradition. However, they are only available in Arabic and Persian. Since this research uses English resources as a starting point for studying the *Sahifah* in English, it relies heavily

on Chittick's Introduction to his translation. The Introduction systematically covers the predominant concepts, doctrines and concerns in the *Sahifah*. Similarly, Syed Muhammad Hossain Jafri's foreword to Chittick's translation is vital for understanding the *Sahifah* as a mystical treatise and its relevance for modern readers.

Apart from these, the paper also includes the English translation of Allama Sayyid Muhammad Baqir al-Sadr and Muhammad Ali Majid's Faqih's introductory commentaries on the *Sahifah* from '*Glimpses of Sahifah al-Sajjadiyyah*' compiled by the Academy of Learning Islam. Additionally, it utilises A Muhani's Introduction to K Bhojani's English translation of the *Sahifah*, titled '*Sahifa al-Kamila*'. These five secondary sources are essential in understanding the *Sahifah*'s importance and place in the Shi'ite tradition and the significance of Al-Sajjad's authorship. Padwick Constance's analysis and criticism of the *Sahifah* and Al-Sajjad in '*Muslim Devotions: a Study of Prayer-manuals in Common Use*' have also been addressed. While all the above-stated sources include biographical details and sayings of Al-Sajjad, the paper predominantly relies on Baqir Sharif Al-Qarashi's biography titled, '*The Life of Imam Zayn al-Abideen*'.

Methodology

Before exploring the *Sahifah*'s relationship with the Quran, locating its author, Al-Sajjad, within the Shi'ite *walayah*, intellectual and spiritual tradition is imperative. Hence,, the first section outlines Al-Sajjad's role and authority in light of the role and authority vested by the Twelve Imams in interpreting and applying Quranic verses. Secondly, the section explains Al-Sajjad's lived experience after the tragedy of Karbala and how it impacted his

psycho-spiritual and socio-political life. Thirdly, the section focuses on Al-Sajjad's personal relationship with the Quran.

The analysis in this section is facilitated by Marie Massi Dakake's book, *'The Charismatic Community: Shi'ite Identity in Early Islam'*, which sheds light on the mysterious and complex concept of *walayah* and the spiritual authority of the Twelve Imams. Similarly, Farhana Mayer's Introduction to *'Spiritual Gems: The Mystical Quran Commentary ascribed to Jafar al-Sadiq'* helps understand the role and authority of the Twelve in interpreting the Quran. Their authority to interpret the Quran is also highlighted in two of Meir M Bar-Asher's papers: *'Introduction: The Quran and its Shi'i interpretations'* and *'The Authority to Interpret the Quran'* found in Farhad Daftari's anthology titled; *'The Study of Shi'i Islam: History, Theology and Law'*. This section also includes discussions by Chittick, Jafri, al-Sadr, Muhani and Faqihi.

Given the dearth of modern scholarship on the *Sahifah*, the second section briefly outlines some crucial aspects of the *Sahifah*. These include its authenticity, the importance of devotional literature and supplication, its role as a mystical treatise, and its address to Constance's criticism of the text and its author. This section primarily relies on the works of Chittick, Jafri, Muhani, al-Sadr and Faqihi. It also includes discussions on devotional literature by Adtandil Erkinov in his research, *'Munajat or Free Religion: A Ritual Shamanistic Song or Spiritual Literature?'*

The first and second sections ground the *Sahifah* and its author within the Shi'ite tradition and provide a necessary discussion as a precursor for the text. Each of the subsequent sections in this research explores an aspect of the relationship between the *Sahifah* and the

Quran. The third section focuses on the stylistic and thematic correspondence between the two texts and demonstrates how *Al-Sajjad* is inspired by the Quran. The *Sahifah's* themes and style are explained through the works of its commentators, especially Chittick, who analyses the relationship between the two texts. Nasr's Introduction to '*The Study Quran*' discusses the Quran's themes and style. The section also utilises the quantitative data in Appendix A.

The fourth section elaborates on one of the most predominant themes in both texts – Allah's Overwhelming Mercy as per His *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*. This section details discussions on the *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat* through Nasr's '*Garden of Truth*' and Chittick's Introduction alongside a quantitative analysis of the Names per Appendix A's data. The last section examines the Quran in light of Allah's Mercy and how *Al-Sajjad* describes its qualities, functions and importance in the *Sahifah*. Since this section seeks to demonstrate *Al-Sajjad's* understanding of the Quran as a Mercy through Quranic verses, it focuses on the correspondence and placement of Quranic verses within the verses of the *Sahifah*. This section primarily focuses on the quantitative analysis in Appendix A and elaborates on the application of some *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*, which will be discussed in the fourth section.

By utilising a quantitative and qualitative lens, this research seeks to establish the relationship between the *Sahifah* and the Quran through the framework of the spiritual authority vested in the Twelve and through the *Sahifah's* language, imagery, motifs and concepts.

Ali ibn Husayn

Al-Sajjad was the son of Husayn ibn Ali (d.61 A.H/680 A.D) and the great-grandson of the Holy Prophet Muhammad (d. 11 A.H/632 A.D) through his daughter Fatima binte Muhammad (d. 11 A.H/632 A.D). According to an acclaimed commentator of the *Sahifah*, Sayyid Muhammad Baqir al-Sadr, Al-Sajjad "grew up under the wing of his erstwhile grandfather, Imam Ali. Later, he came under the tutelage of his uncle, Imam Hasan, and his father" (al-Sadr, 1). According to Nasr, Ali ibn Abi Talib (d 42. A.H/661 A.D) is "the most important figure in Sufism" and "the main inheritor of the [Prophet's] esoteric teachings" who is "as revered among Sunni Sufis as he is among Shi'ites (Nasr 2011, 167). Similarly, Al-Sajjad's uncle Hasan ibn Ali (d. 50A.H/669 A.D) "is considered the person who taught the esoteric interpretation of the Quran and sowed the seed of Sufism..." (Nasr 2011, 169). While Al-Husayn is considered one of the greatest martyrs in Islamic history. Hence, Al-Sajjad's upbringing and influences place him squarely within the early Islamic intellectual and mystical tradition.

Before analysing the contents of the *Sahifah* and its relationship with the Quran, it is crucial to contextualise its author within the Shi'i and larger mystical Islamic tradition. To establish the correspondence and relationship between the *Sahifah* and the Quran, it is necessary to explore the relationship between Allah and Al-Sajjad. Hence, this section will focus on Al-Sajjad's life in the context of i) the spiritual authority and the authority to interpret the Quran, vested in the Twelve Imams as per the Shi'ite traditions. ii) The tragedy of Karbala and its psychological, socio-political and spiritual effects on the author. iii) Al-Sajjad's personal relationship with the Quran reflects the *Sahifah's* relationship with it as 'the sister of the Quran'.

Spiritual Authority

To understand Al-Sajjad's spiritual and exegetical authority, station and prowess, it is imperative to ground him within the *walayah/wilayah* doctrines of the Shi'ite and Sufi traditions. These doctrines hold the Twelve Imams as the highest authority after the Holy Prophet to interpret and explain the Quran. Furthermore, the relationship between the *Sahifah* and the Quran is founded upon the Shi'ite doctrine that "... the *Imam* is considered the true interpreter of the book" (Mayer, xv). "In the Shi'i doctrine of the *Imam's* knowledge, the *Imam* is the speaking Quran (*Quran natiq*) while the Quran is the silent *Imam* (*Imam sanat*)" (Mayer, xv).

According to Dakake, the term *walayah* outlines "the nature of spiritual authority" vested in the Twelve Imams alongside delineating the "underlying principles" of the "common bond" between those who consider themselves "members" of the Shi'ite and Sufi communities (Dakake, 15). *Wilayah*, on the other hand, is a "limited authority", which is "confined" and "subject to a higher authority" (Dakake, 16). In Shi'ism, the limited *wilayah* authority is reserved for the Twelve Imams, who are considered the spiritual heirs of the Prophet. According to Sadr-al-Din Al-Shirazi (d.1050 A.H), a prominent theosopher from the Isfahan School during the Safavid era, the doctrines of *walayah* and *wilayah* are embedded within the Holy Prophet's "genealogical descendants" and "his spiritual heirs" (Dakake, 27). Al-Shirazi, commonly known as Mullah Sadra, further notes that Shi'ite Imams occupy the unique position where "the genealogical and spiritual lines of inheritance converge" (Dakake, 27).

In *Tuhfah-yi Abbasi: The Gold Chain of Sufism in Shi'ite Islam*, Muhammad Ali Sabzvari writes that "The inerrant Imam is considered as the universal guide, friend of God (*wali-e-kull*), whose grace flows through the particular pole (*wali-e-ju'z*)" (Sabzvari, xii). Similarly, in Sufi traditions, Ibn al-Arabi (d.1240 C.E) states that *walayah* represents a "spiritualised form of mutual support between God and his faithful devotees", which holds immense "metaphysical and mystical significance" (Dakake, 30). Henry Corbin states that in Sufism, the doctrines of *walayah* in the "context of Divine-human relationships have a firm basis in the Quran, which identifies Allah as the *Wali* ... par excellence" (Dakake, 30).

Indeed, this notion is built upon a foundation of Quranic references, which state that after Allah, the Holy Prophet is the best *wali* for Muslims due to the 'Muhammeden Light' vested in him (Nasr 2011, 107) as highlighted in 4:80; 4:59 and 33:21. According to Nasr, Shi'ite and Sufi mystical traditions and *walayah* doctrines outline Ali ibn Abi Talib and the other Twelve Shi'a Imams as *the* spiritual authorities by their inheritance of the 'Muhammeden Light' (Nasr 2015, 630). Chittick also observes that "Muslims obeying Allah depended upon imitating those ... shaped by Allah's mercy ... for the Shias, the words and acts of the Imam play a basic role in this respect" (Chittick 1988, xxvii). Although Sufi mystical traditions also consider Sufi masters apart from the Prophet's descendants as endowed with *walayah* and *wilayah*, there is no disagreement on the prominent role of Ali ibn Abi Talib and his progeny in the esoteric and mystical traditions of Islam.

According to the prominent Sufi Al-Hujviri (d.464A.H/1072 C.E) in his magnum opus *Kashf ul Mahjoob*, Al-Sajjad is "the most blessed man in this world and in the next" (Al-Hujviri, 76). Moreover, Al-Hujviri establishes Al-Sajjad as one who possesses "the character" of "those who have attained perfect rectitude (*kamil-e-mustaquidin*)" (Al-Hujviri,

76). Nasr states that while Shi'ism and Sufism may differ in their exoteric, political modalities, they stem from 'a singular reality' (Nasr 2011, 170). Similarly, Mayer comments on the realities of Shi'ism and Sufism as "two routes to sanctity... which share a meeting point" (Mayer, xxx). The singular reality, or sanctity, is the quest for The Divine, which begins and ends at The Divine despite the infinite paths between the two points.

Love and *walayah*

A profound aspect of mystical Islam is love for The Divine, through the Divine and for the sake of the Divine. This mysterious but intrinsic component of gnostic Islam is also present in the *walayah* tradition, rooted in love, reverence, and friendship for the Household of the Prophet. The love is multi-dimensional in which The Divine, The Holy Prophet, the household of the Prophet and devout Muslims share a common bond. A hadith of the Prophet outlines this bond: "Love Allah for the blessings by which He nourishes you, love me for the love of Allah, and love the people of my house for the love of me" (at-Tabrizi, 3789). Similarly, when the Prophet was asked how Muslims should send blessings upon him, he replied:

'Say, O Allah, bless Muhammad and the Family of Muhammad, just as you blessed Abraham and the family of Abraham. Verily you are Praiseworthy and Glorious. And send benediction on Muhammad and on the family of Muhammad, just as you sent Your benediction on Abraham and on the family of Abraham. Verily you are Praiseworthy and Glorious" (al-Dīn, 3993).

This hadith of the Prophet is known as *durood sharif*, and is one of the most often repeated invocations for all Muslims, not just Shi'is. Similarly, in Shi'ism, a tradition associated with the fifth *Imam* Muhammad Al-Baqir (114 A.H/743 C.E) and the sixth *Imam* Jafar Al-Sadiq (d. 148 A.H/765 C.E) says, "The heaviest thing to be placed on the scales on the Day of

Resurrection is the invocation of blessings on Muhammad and his Household” (Majlisi, 49).

The importance of loving the Holy Prophet and his family and seeking their intercession is evident throughout the *Sahifah*. Supplication 57, 'His Supplication in Mentioning the Household of Muhammad', is dedicated to them, while supplication 2 and 5 also speak about the household of Muhammad⁷. Thirteen supplications begin with verses sending blessings on them⁸, while eight supplications end with such verses⁹. The shortened *durood sharif*, which is most common in the Shi'ite tradition (O Allah, send blessing on Muhammad (A.S) and the Household of Muhammad) occurs throughout the text 209 times¹⁰, while twice blessings are sent upon them, formats other than the brief *durood sharif*. Sending blessings on the Household of the Prophet is the second most repeated concept in the *Sahifah*, only after the mention of Allah's infinite Mercy¹¹, emphasising the importance of the house of the Prophet in accessing the Divine and the Quran.

Authority to interpret the Quran

In Islamic doctrines, the role of the House of the Prophet (*ahle-bait*) is exceptionally profound due to their contributions to the exoteric Islamic intellectual and esoteric psycho-spiritual traditions. Moreover, in the Shi'i tradition, the Twelve Imams have the authority to guide the Muslim *ummah* and interpret the Quran (Chittick, Introduction, xxvii,xvi, S. M. Jafri, ii). Mayer says that "a central aspect of the Shi'i Imam's divinely conferred

⁷ Table 1.

⁸ Table 2.

⁹ Table 3.

¹⁰ Table 6.

¹¹ Table 6.

knowledge (*ilm*) is the correct interpretation of the Quran" (Mayer, xvi). Hence, the relationship between the Quran and the *Sahifah* is seen as divinely conferred, like the relationship between Allah and the infallible Imams, is indoctrinated as divinely conferred.

There are various verses in the Quran on the authority to interpret it, such as 2:218, 3:7, 3:31, 3:138, 4:83, 12:76, 22:26, 23:62 and 41:44. According to Mayer, in al-Sadiq's *tafsir* of 3:138, "the Shi'i doctrine that only the *Imams* understand the Quran correctly is implied" (Mayer, xix). Similarly, in the explanation of 41:44, Al-Sadiq explains the Shi'i doctrines of "the infallibility (*ismah*) of the Imams ... [and their] ... true understanding of the Quran, which only the Imams have as part of their divinely conferred knowledge (*ilm*)" (Mayer, xxx). In interpreting verse 23:62 regarding the "... Book speaking the truth", Abu Rajab al-Bursi (d. 813/1411) says that "the Speaking Book is the friend [of God, *i.e.* the Imam]" (M. M. Bar-Asher 2014, 155). Al-Baqir explains that "the ones firmly rooted in knowledge ... [are] ... pure and protected from sin and error, and they are the light of God by which people may walk and be guided aright" (Lalani 2004, 70). According to Bar-Asher, 3:7 is the "most widely known verses invoked which endorse" the supremacy of the Imam's knowledge when it refers to "those firmly rooted in knowledge (*wa'l rasikhuna fi'l-ilm*)" (M. M. Bar-Asher 2014, 151).

A tradition associated with Ali refers to the Household of the Prophet as the 'friends of Allah':

The friends of Allah (*awliya-e-Allah*) are those who look at the inward side of the world while others look at its outward side. They busy themselves with its remote benefits, while others busy themselves with the immediate benefits ... through them, the Book is learnt, and they have learnt through the Book (al-Raḍī 1971, 1287).

The *Sahifah* also refers to 'the friends of God' from Surah Yunus verses 62 and 64, which states that "no fear shall come upon" them "nor shall they grieve" and that they have been promised "glad tidings in this world and in their Hereafter" due to their exalted station and perfection of worship"¹². While there are many interpretations of these verses, in the Shi'ite tradition, they refer to the Twelve Imams.

In 'the hadith of two weighty things' (*hadith al-thaqalayn*), the Holy Prophet (S.A.W) says:

"Verily, I have left behind what will never lead you astray if you hold fast to them. One of them is greater than the other: the Book of Allah is a rope extended from the heavens to the earth, and my family, the people of my household. They will not dissent until they return to me at the Fountain, so look at how you treat them after me" (at-Tabrizi, 3788).

In Bar-Asher's analysis of this *hadith*, "the *al-thaqalayn* are thus intertwined with each other forever" (M. M. Bar-Asher 2014, 154). Another prominent *hadith* in Sunni, Shi'i and Sufi traditions defines "Ali's role as a fighter for the interpretation of the Quran, just as the Prophet himself fought for its revelation" (M. M. Bar-Asher 2014, 156). According to Bar-Asher, unlike others, "the prevalent view in Shi'i exegetical tradition" is that "the authority to interpret the Quran does not lie with ordinary believers". Instead, the "privilege" to interpret the Quran is "exclusive to Ali and his descendants, the Imams ... as they are the recipients of divine knowledge" (M. M. Bar-Asher 2014, 151). A tradition associated with Ali ibn Abi Talib also explains the relationship between the Quran, its meaning and interpreters:

¹² Table 5(c).

God, in the breath of His Mercy and His Compassion, divided His words [in the Quran] into three parts:" one part is intelligible to both the learned and the ignorant; another part is intelligible only to those pure of mind, delicate sensitivity and correct discernment among those whose heart God has opened to Islam; and another part is intelligible only to God and His prophets and to those firmly rooted in knowledge" (M. M. Bar-Asher 2014, 93).

Similarly, on the correct interpretation of the Quran, Al-Sajjad says that:

"The religion of Allah ... is not attained by incomplete intellect, false opinions and corrupt measures. It is not attained but through submission. Whoever submits to us is safe, and whoever follows us is guided" (Al-Qarashi, 86).

While on the role of the Imams and their relationship to the Quran, Al-Sajjad says:

O Allah! Surely You have confirmed Your religion in all times, with an Imam whom You have set as a guidepost to Your servants and a lighthouse in Your lands after his cord has been joined to Your cord! You have made him the means of your good pleasure. Through him you establish Your Book and Your Bounty" (Al-Qarashi, 87).

Through the relationship of the *Imams* with the Quran and the *walayah* doctrine in the Shi'i tradition, it becomes clear that the relationship of the *Sahifah* as the sister of the Quran (*ukhat al-Quran*) is not coincidental but intentional. Moreover, it signifies how Al-Sajjad has been endowed with the divine knowledge and exclusive privilege of representing the feminine, esoteric spirit of the Quran. The *Sahifah*, with its emphasis on Allah's overwhelming Mercy, highlights the feminine (*Jamali*) aspects of Allah's Nature. In Shi'ism, as only the Shi'i Imams have access to the inner realities of the Quran, they also act as intercessors for believers wanting to access these realities. Hence, through the feminine, gentle spirit of the *Sahifah*, one can access the Quran's overwhelmingly merciful and esoteric meanings.

Karbala

Al-Sajjad was also a primary participant in the tragedy of Karbala during the turbulent Umayyad reign in the late 7th century when the Islamic polity was rift with civil strife. The battle of Karbala (61 A.H/680C.E) was a one-day battle between Al-Sajjad's father, Husayn ibn Ali and Yazid ibn Muwaiyya's (d. 64 A.H/683C.E) army (Chittick 1988, xvi, Al-Qarashi, 135). The events leading up to the battle, the battle and its aftermath have greatly influenced all spheres of Islamic history to date. Al-Husayn's army was massacred on the plains of Taif, and Al-Sajjad, alongside the women and children of the House of the Prophet (*ahle-bait*), was imprisoned by Yazid and subjected to inhumane atrocities (Chittick 1988, xvi, Al-Qarashi, 142,145). Allama Majlisi in the *Bihar al-Anwar* narrates a tradition from Al-Sajjad on the battle of Karbala:

There was no day like the day of al-Husayn, when thirty thousand men advanced against him (while) they claimed that they belonged to the community and that they (wanted) to seek proximity to Allah, the Great and Almighty, through (shedding) his blood. He (Al-Husayn) reminded them of Allah, but they did not learn (from him) till they killed him out of (their) oppression and aggression (Al-Qarashi, 135).

Witnessing his family's inhumane slaughter had an everlasting impact on Al-Sajjad. Sometime after Karbala, his servant asked him whether it was time for his sorrow to end. He replied saying:

"Woe upon you! Jacob the Prophet had twelve sons and Allah made one of them disappear, so Jacob's eyes turned white from constant weeping, his head turned grey out of sorrow and his back became bent in gloom though his son was alive in this world. But I watched while my father, my brother, my uncle and seventeen members of my family were slaughtered all around me. How should my sorrow come to an end?" (Al-Qarashi, 163, Chittick 1988, xvi).

The tragedy of Karbala is regarded as one of the darkest events in Islamic history, when the Holy Prophet's grandson and his family were slaughtered without food or water, merely fifty years after the passing of the Prophet. Al-Sajjad's outward socio-political realities

were significantly affected by the overwhelming grief and trauma of the massacre of the Holy Prophet's family. Faqihi states that "history testifies that Imam Sajjad led the Shi'ah through one of the harshest periods of history during his 34 years of Imamate. This period offered naught but suppression" (Faqihi 2017, 3). Jafri poetically describes Al-Sajjad during this period as:

“...a person who found himself caught up in the din and clamour of his life, in the clash of emotions and interests, in the stress and strain of immediate impulses, in the tensions and calamities of existence” (S. M. Jafri, xii)

His mystical and spiritual insight in the *Sahifah* stems from the depths of human suffering – from the loss and mourning of loved ones to the humiliation, oppression and helplessness of captivity to poverty and mistreatment. However, exoteric events never affected the inner resilience of his servitude and worship due to his perfected rectitude, spiritual authority and responsibility to guide the Muslim *ummah*. According to Muhani, "he was no pessimist, and his prayers, which inspire hope at every step, support this view of his character" (Muhani, 8). His resilience and unwavering faith are evident in his attitude towards humanity, life in this world and Allah in the *Sahifah*.

Al-Sajjad's life and mystical philosophy, as transmitted through the *Sahifah*, depict a spiritually wayfaring soul. In one of his prayers, he says, "I am not despairing" Muhani notes that "this attitude is accounted for by the fact that he had made the will of God his only standard of happiness" (Muhani, 8). Al-Sajjad transcends the relative evil of the world and turns to the Absolute Good and Mercy of the Divine. Jafri further states that he was:

"Above all, in the search for spiritual satisfaction, a lonely and helpless man who stood before his Creator in direct communion and called Him from the very depths of his heart" (S. M. Jafri, xii).

Despite such cruel, overwhelming, temporal distractions, the sole focus of his existence is best presented in the compendium of supplications found in the *Sahifah* that establish, foster, and celebrate an elite spiritual connection with the Divine.

The quietist Imam

When Al-Sajjad returned from captivity in Damascus along with his wife Fatima binte Hasan (d. 117 A.H/735-6) and aunts Zainab binte Ali (d. 63 A.H/682 C.E) and Umme Kulsoom binte Ali (b. 6 A.H/627 C.E) to Medina, he began the tradition of quietist Imams (Chittick 1988, xvi, Constance, xvi). At this time, Shi'ite revolts against the Umayyads, such as the '*Tawwabun* movement' were popular, and many felt that "it was the duty of the Imam to lead a revolt" (Chittick 1988, xvii). However, Al-Sajjad refused any political or military involvement against the perpetrators of Karbala. So much so that he "refused to make any public claims or to allow any claims to be made on his behalf" (S. H. Jafri 2000, 240). Al-Sadr said Al-Sajjad "took over the mantle of spiritual responsibility ... during one of the most crucial phases in the history of the *ummah*" (al-Sadr, 3). Muhani says that "the Imam's purpose in life was neither vengeance nor the seizure of political power. His object was only to keep the spark of spiritual life glowing and the torch of guidance burning" (Muhani, 8).

Such a lack of interest in seeking revenge undermines Constance's claims of the *Sahifah* being "characterised by ... an intransigent, undying resentment against the foes of his house" (Constance, xvi). Perhaps Constance was influenced by the overwhelming resentment of the Muslim world towards the foes of the Prophet's household, especially the

Umayyad dynasty, which has been well preserved in the Shi'i and the Sunni and Sufi traditions.

For example, in *Kashf al-Mahjoob*, Al-Hujviri curses Yazid and recounts an encounter between Al-Sajjad, the Umayyad caliph Hisham ibn Abd Al-Malik (d. 125 A.H/743 A.H) and an Arabic poet Farazdaq (d. 728-730 AD/110-112 AH) at Mecca (Al-Hujviri, 76). Al-Malik felt slighted, as the crowds at the *Ka'ba* did not give him a way to reach the Black Stone (*Hajar e aswad*) but parted in "veneration" for the Imam. In that instance, Farazdaq recited a poem praising Al-Sajjad as "he whose footprint is known to the valley of Mecca, He whom the Temple knows ... This is the pious, the elect, the pure the eminent" (Al-Hujviri, 77). Al-Hujviri said, "Hisham was enraged and threw Farazdaq into prison". When Al-Sajjad sent Farazdaq compensation for the panegyric – as per the Arabic tradition of the time – Farazdaq refused, saying that he "had uttered many lies in the panegyrics on princes and governors which he was accustomed to compose for money" (Al-Hujviri, 77). Farazdaq further stated that he composed verses praising Al-Sajjad as "partial expiation for his sins, and as a proof of his affection towards the House of the Prophet" (Al-Hujviri, 77).

Such incidents are replete within the lives of the Imams and well documented in hagiographies and historical records, which may give Western scholars like Constance the impression that it was Al-Sajjad in the *Sahifah* and not his followers who bore an obvious "undying resentment against the foes of (their) house" (Constance, xvi). At times, the *Sahifah* 'alludes' to "the injustices suffered by his family" and over the 'usurpation of their right inheritance' – however ", no one can call this a major theme ... [in it]" (Chittick 1988, xx). Whenever the Imam recalled the tragedy of Karbala and its aftermath, it was always

"... accompanied by an admission of Allah's wisdom in His ordainment" (Chittick, Introduction, xx).

Al-Baqir and Al-Sadiq, following the legacy of Al-Sajjad's quietism, would spread their knowledge, jurisprudence and wisdom in the Islamic community. However, they, too, did not engage in the power politics of the Islamic world at large (Chittick, Introduction, xvii). At a crucial juncture in the Islamic polity, when political and military power was being consolidated, Al-Sajjad instead focused on the inner, esoteric, mystical and on man's personal relationship with God. According to Muhani, Al-Sajjad's:

"sermons, addresses, even conversations were being constantly watched by the Umayyad rulers, but his prayers were among the only things which aroused no suspicion, so the Imam employed this mode of imparting to his followers the knowledge of the true faith" (Muhani, 13).

It is poignant to note that a resounding legacy of knowledge, codification and canonisation of Shi'ite doctrines is associated with the quietist Imams. Chronologically speaking, Al-Sajjad focused on the mystical branch of Shi'ite Islam despite being an accomplished jurist expert in Prophetic *ahadith* and Quranic exegesis. After him, his son Al-Baqir enshrined the Imamate doctrine, and his grandson Al-Sadiq established the Shi'ite school of jurisprudence (*fiqh*). Highlighting the precedence and importance of the esoteric realities of Islam and the Quran, upon which doctrines of spiritual leadership and law are established.

Piety

In his foreword to Chittick's translation of the *Sahifah* Syed Muhammad Jafri states that "Zayn al-Abideen derived his religious and spiritual authority and his divine knowledge in the closest and most intimate way through his father, grandfather and from the Apostle of God" (S. M. Jafri, ix) Hence, for mystically inclined Muslims, whether Sufi, Shi'a or Sunni, the best form of guidance in mystical matters and spiritual journeys are those within whom Allah has vested esoteric knowledge, spiritual love and the ability and duty to guide the Muslim brethren (*ummah*) (Chittick 1988, xxvii).

Jafri further states that Al-Sajjad's role as an intellectual, religious and spiritual authority is evident in his occupation as a learned jurist and leading traditionist of his time (S. M. Jafri, ix). According to al-Sadr, he "was considered a high authority in jurisprudence and religious sciences", a "leader", and "known for his exemplary devotion and piety" (al-Sadr, 2). According to Chittick, he was "... an authority on prophetic traditions and law, but was mostly known for his nobility of character and his piety..." (Chittick 1988, xvi). Constance also agrees that the Islamic "tradition shows him as giving his life to piety" (Constance, xvi). Reverence and respect for the fourth Imam were not restricted to Ali'd loyalists or Banu Hashim's tribal ties during his time. Rather he:

"... was widely respected by the community ... [even his political opponents] ... for his extraordinary qualities... such as ... his prayer, piety ... learning and generosity" (S. M. Jafri, x).

This is reflected in his honorific title (Zayn al-Abideen), 'the Ornament of the Worshippers', which was given to him by Al-Zuhri, a jurist at the Ummayyad court (S. M. Jafri, x, Chittick 1988, xvi). However, Shi'i historians like Al-Qarashi insist that this title was bestowed on Al-Sajjad by the Prophet (Al-Qarashi, 17). In any case, Al-Sajjad is the only spiritual figurehead in Islam, known as Zayn al-Abideen. According to al-Sadr, "he was a spiritual

leader and supreme spiritual authority [for those] belonging to various schools of thought in all matters – both civic and spiritual" (al-Sadr, 2).

Al-Sajjad and the Quran

One of the hallmarks of Al-Sajjad's piety was his relationship with and enthusiasm for the Quran, which translates into the *Sahifah's* intimate relationship with Quranic verses, language, imagery, motifs and tone. Al-Sajjad says, "If those between the East and the West died, I would not feel lonely, for the Quran is with me" (Al-Qarashi, 270). Similarly, Al-Qarashi reports that:

"The Imam did not recite the Holy Quran with a passing recitation. Rather, he recited its verses with reflection and scrutiny. He carefully considered the treasure of wisdom and knowledge therein. Hence, he [al-Sajjad] said: "The verses of the Quran are treasures. Whenever you open a treasure of them, you must consider it carefully" (Al-Qarashi, 278).

Al-Sajjad's careful consideration of and dedication to the Quran is evident in how the *Sahifah* quotes, engages with and emphasises Quranic verses. The *Sahifah's* engagement with the Quran is discussed in greater detail in a subsequent section.

Additionally, his authorship of one of the first prayer manuals in Islamic history shows his devotion and enthusiasm for worship. Jafri says that "it was Ali b. al-Husayn, the Zayn al-Abideen of Islam, who ... taught Muslims the essence of Islamic spirituality through his supplications" (S. M. Jafri, ii). He also exercised significant influence on and was instrumental in contributing to the techniques, language, imagery and tone of supplications in the widely read and prolific genre of Islamic devotional literature.

Al-Sahifah al-Sajjadiyah

According to al-Sadr, the *Sahifah* "stands out as a profound social work of the time and a supreme endeavour to meet the exigencies of spiritual ordeals" (al-Sadr, 5) in Islamic society. Muhani regards it as "one of the best collections of devotional literature in the world" (Muhani, 22), which may be counted among the miracles of Arabic literature" (Muhani, 28). Al-Sadr also claims that the *Sahifah* is endowed with Al-Sajjad's "wonderful rhetoric and elegant style in the Arabic language" (al-Sadr, 2). He further states that "the Imam was able to weave the most splendid and subtle meanings in his description of the links between the human being and the Divine" (al-Sadr, 5). Muhani contends that "the *Sahifah* reveals the loftiness of the mind that produced it and with exact knowledge of human nature, fervent devotion, earnest love ... which were essential parts of [Al-Sajjad's] character" (Muhani, 22).

Similarly, Faqihi maintains that the supplications in the *Sahifah* "are from a person who enjoys the loftiest station of God's gnosis and possesses the most intense love for him" (Faqihi, 4). Faqihi further contends that the language of the *Sahifah* and other supplications from the *ahle-bait* "are rarely seen in traditions, along with their mystical teachings" (Faqihi, 6). He reasons that "the Imams were obliged to address people. However, in their supplications, they would address God directly and, therefore, manifest what lay in their hearts. As a result, a great number of esoteric teachings can be derived from them" (Faqihi, 6).

The *Sahifah* encapsulates an impressive and expansive breadth of thematic concerns and topics. The Arabic book, titled 'A Guide to the Themes of the Sahifah' (*Al-dalīl ilā mawdu*

āt al-Sahīfah al-Sajjādiyyah) by Muhammad Husayn Muzaffar, the book has "nineteen major themes [with], subthemes: Unity of God, Prophethood, Imamate, Resurrection, Islam, Angels, Moral traits, Acts of devotional worship, Invocations and supplications, Politics, Economics, Man, Creation, Society, Knowledge, Time, History, Health and Military" (Faqihi, 3).

According to Muhani, "It is not merely a book of prayers. It is a testament of life in its varied aspects" (Muhani, 23). Chittick also says it covers "that dimension of Islam which deals with the practical and lived reality of the personal relationship between man and Allah" (Chittick 1988, xxviii). This is similar to the thematic concerns of the Quran, "which is at once sapiential and practical, legal and moral, concerned with everyday problems as well as the spiritual and intellectual life" (Nasr, Introduction 2015, 25).

Nasr states that the Quran is; "*the* fundamental source of law"; "*the* book of ethics"; which "contains teachings on economics, politics for the individual believer and Islamic society as a whole" (Nasr, Introduction 2015, 22). He also regards it as "a guide for the inner spiritual life" and an archive of "sacred history" (Nasr, Introduction 2015, 23). Similarly, Al-Qarashi refers to the *Sahifah* as "one of the most important books of eloquence, education, ethics and literature in Islam" (Al-Qarashi, 378). A closer look at the *Sahifah's* supplication titles, thematic concerns, Quranic references and allusions demonstrate how "thoroughly the text is grounded within the Revealed book" (Chittick 1988, xlv). The firm foundations of the *Sahifah* in the Quran are mainly reflected in the Quranic verses referenced by Al-Sajjad within various supplications¹³. The *Sahifah* is well-rounded in

¹³ Table 4.

helping believers thematically and spiritually engage with the Quran by quoting relevant portions that align with various human states and modalities. Referencing Quranic verses as words of Allah – is itself one of the most fascinating aspects of the *Sahifah* – as in his authorship of a one-on-one dialogue with Allah, Al-Sajjad is quoting Allah to Allah, which is to say – using Allah's words while in direct communion with Him.

Before moving on to the relationship between the content, characteristics and qualities of the Quran and the *Sahifah*, the dearth of modern scholarship on the *Sahifah* necessitates a brief discussion on i) the *Sahifah's* authenticity, ii) the importance of supplication in the Islamic tradition and the relevance of devotional literature to the modern world, iii) the *Sahifah* as a mystical treatise and not just a prayer manual due to its divinely inspired authorship, and iv) criticism on Al-Sajjad's status as an infallible (*masum*) Imam seeking forgiveness in the *Sahifah*.

Authenticity

According to the Shi'ite tradition, Al-Sajjad wrote, compiled and structured the *Sahifah* alongside teaching it to his children, particularly Al-Baqir and Zayd ibn Ali bin Al-Husayn (d. 122 A.H/ 740 C.E). It was then "disseminated among Shias of all persuasions" (Chittick 1988, xviii). Alongside his grandson Al-Sadiq, Al-Sajjad's sons were the primary transmitters and teachers of the text. *Al-Sahifah-al-Sajjadiyya*, in its current form, has fifty-four supplications, an addendum of prayers for the days of the week, and fifteen whispered prayers (*munajat*) (Chittick 1988, xviii).

There were at least five variants of the *Sahifah* till the late 17th century. However, the synthesis of this finalised version was consolidated by Allama Muhammad Baqir Majlisi

(d.1110 A.H/1698-9 A.D) in his "monumental compilation of Shi'ite hadith, *Bihar al-anwar* (Chittick 1988, xviii). The fifteen *munajat* were added by Majlisi from *Al-Kitab al-Atiq Gharawi*, which he found in Najaf, "compiled by one of the ancient authorities in hadith (*ba'd qudama al-muhaddithin*)" (Chittick 1988, xviii). According to Al-Qarashi, the chain of authorities for the *Sahifah* includes over fifty-six thousand reliable sources (Al-Qarashi, 379). Chittick further confirms that *hadith* specialists "maintain that the text is *mutawatir* [which is to say] it was generally known from earliest times ... while its authenticity has never been questioned" (Chittick 1988, xviii).

In modern scholarship, Constance Padwick has critically commented on the *Sahifah* in her book on Islamic supplications, 'Muslim Devotions'. However, she has not assessed the authenticity of individual supplications; instead, she accepts them under the authority of Allama Majlisi. According to Chittick, verifying the "historical reliability" of each supplication "on the basis of modern scholarship" would be a monumental task. He also wonders whether such an inconclusive study would be pertinent to anyone but "Western scholars and modernised Muslims" (Chittick 1988, xix). He argues that "historians" accepting the "text as completely authentic" does not alter the "actual influence which Zayn al-Abideen and the *Sahifah* have exercised upon Islam over the centuries, nor is it likely to change the way they continue to influence practising Muslims" (Chittick, Introduction, xx).

Constance also agrees that a certain "romance is woven around this saintly figure" (Constance, xvi). Chittick concludes that this is especially true for Shi'ite Muslims, who have known Zayn al-Abideen "... for more than a thousand years ... [as the one] ... who has helped give Shi'ism its specific contours down to the present day" (Chittick,

Introduction, xix). Whether or not the *Sahifah* can or should be authenticated by modern scholarship has no bearing on how devout Shi'i Muslims perceive it as the words of their beloved Imam.

Supplication in worship

Unlike Islam's obligatory five pillars of worship, there are no prescribed regulations or obligations in making supplications or whispered prayers. Instead, they can be categorised as a "free prayer" rather than an obligatory prayer (Erkinov, 87). Supplication (*dua*) means "to call upon" Allah (Chittick 1988, xxiv). Hence, the *Sahifah* is considered a part of essential but supererogatory prayers. Meanwhile, *munajat*, a subcategory of supplication, means "to whisper/to call upon in secret" (Erkinov, 85). The Quran encourages Muslims to "Call upon your Lord humbly and in secret" [7:55]. Al-Razi's exegesis of the verse defines *such secrecy* as a remembrance and plea, which encapsulates "sincerity", "humility", and "lack of hypocrisy" (Nasr 2015, 930).

In *ahadith* literature from Shia, Sunni and Sufi traditions, the importance of supplication is repetitively emphasised through sayings of the Prophet, such as "Supplication is the pith of worship" (at-Tabrizi, 77). In another *hadith*, The Prophet says: "supplication is the weapon of the man of faith, the centre of the pole of religion, and the light of the heavens and the earth" (Chittick 1988, xxv). In the Shi'ite tradition, the Imams also emphasise supplicating; Ali ibn Abi Talib says, "The best speech, in the eyes of God, is a great amount of *dhikr*, pleading (*tadarru*) and supplication (Chittick 1988, xxv). When describing the Prophet's *sunnah*, Al-Husayn said that he "...used to raise his hands when he implored and supplicated, like a man in misery begging for food" (Chittick 1988, xxv).

In the Islamic tradition, especially mystical traditions: "supplication is the flesh and blood of the spiritual imagination... [and] ... an intimate expression and profession of God's Unity which shaped their sensibilities, emotions, thoughts and concepts" (Chittick 1988, xxvii). In his Introduction to the *Sahifah*, Chittick establishes devotional literature such as *duas* and *munajats* as a "primary framework" in which the human soul may be "moulded in accordance to Divine Will" and 'egoistic concepts' which serve as distractions and obstacles that can be "discarded" (Chittick 1988, xxvii). According to Erkinov, the mystical format of supplications takes ordinary "Muslim piety" to extraordinary "mystical experiences", which are only possible due to a "secret mystical communication with God" (Erkinov, 87). Indeed, communicating a yearning for Allah's proximity is one of the central themes of the *Sahifah*.

Supplicating in the *Sahifah*

The second most often quoted verse (40:60) from the Quran in the *Sahifah* is about supplicating to Allah, and His attribution of being The Responder (Al-Mujeeb)¹⁴, while three unique Quranic verses quoted in the *Sahifah* refer to Allah as The Responder¹⁵. In verse (40:60), which is referenced five times, Allah says, "Call upon Me, and I shall respond to you". The third most quoted Quranic verse in the *Sahifah* is (2:186), which occurs thrice¹⁶;

"When My servants ask thee about Me, truly I am near. I answer the call of the caller when he calls Me. So let them respond to Me and believe in Me, that they may be led aright."

¹⁴ Table 4.

¹⁵ Table 5(c).

¹⁶ Table 4.

Similarly (27:62) is directly referenced twice and alluded to once¹⁷, in which the Quran describes Allah's nature as: "He, Who answers the one in distress when he calls upon Him". Allah's Attribution of being the Responder occurs thirty-two times throughout the *Sahifah*¹⁸. The emphasis on Allah as The Responder and the importance of supplication in the *Sahifah* reflects the Quranic emphasis on supplicating and turning to Allah. The *Sahifah's* premise of being a book of supplications is predicated upon the fact that Allah has made Himself known as the All-Seeing (*Al-Baseer*), All-Hearing (*Al-Sami*)¹⁹ Responder Herein, the function of the *Sahifah* is to nurture and encourage the desire for an Allah-centric approach to shaping the human psyche and soul. Al-Sajjad depicts supplication as a one-on-one dialogue between believers and Allah. Allah is most responsive and receptive and actively engages with creation and their various psycho-spiritual and socio-economic conditions. For example, in 'The Whispered Prayers of the Lovers' and 'The Whispered Prayers of the Knowers', knowledge and love of Allah are depicted as the highest aspirations of the human soul in worship. Hence, Al-Sajjad guides believers on how to love and know Allah while describing Allah's love for believers and the knowledge He sent to them.

Furthermore, devotional literature can also be viewed as part of the *adab* of spirituality, which is the "comportment, courtesy, culture, refined speech, literature and correct ethical attitudes" (Nasr 2011, 89). The goal of supplication as *adab* is to "control the ego and passions" alongside inducing the "virtues of humility and charity" whilst "bringing out the majestic", esoteric and hidden "aspects of our existence" (Nasr 2011, 90). The Quran also

¹⁷ Table 4.

¹⁸ Table 6.

¹⁹ Table 5(a).

speaks about *adab* as a means "for obtaining forgiveness and proximity of God" (Surah al-Hujarat) (Nasr 2015, 2781).

A timeless mystical treatise

According to Chittick, the *Sahifah* was composed in the historical context of the early Islamic community, which was deeply devoted to worship (Chittick 1988, xxvii). For pious Muslims, making supplications helps believers:

“... Keep the thought of Him present throughout their daily activities. An intimate expression of *tawheed* or the ‘profession of Allah’s Unity’ which shapes their sensibilities, emotions, thoughts and concepts” (Chittick 1988, xxvii).

Devotional literature is also dedicated to pursuing spiritual advancement and excellence in worship – especially during collective and individual socio-political and psycho-spiritual crises of faith. Such crises are hallmarks of the modern world, which has aggrandised spiritual poverty in the face of materialism and nihilism. However, the timeless and esoteric nature of the *Sahifah* emphasises the fact that the exoteric realities of any time and space cannot reduce the importance of "the personal quality of Allah's relationship with his servants and His all-pervading Love" (Chittick 1988, xxviii).

Hence, it is fitting to treat the *Sahifah* as a mystical treatise and not merely a prayer manual, as it systematically and thematically encourages believers to pursue spiritual purity and ascension, no matter how strenuous or comfortable their environments may be. There is an emphasis on the distressful states of the human condition, which Jafri describes as Al-Sajjad's commitment to God and "the sufferings of humanity" He forms a "bond of pain with the men of his time" and "those who came after him" (S. M. Jafri, xi). Hence, Al-Sajjad's readership encapsulates Muslims worldwide across fourteen hundred years. Such

a bond and commitment, according to Jafri, helps believers move beyond viewing "religion as part of history and a social phenomenon" to encouraging "man's encounter with the Divine" (S. M. Jafri, xii).

Humankind's encounter or lack of engaged interaction with the Divine must be looked at as an individual crisis of faith in light of socio-political "forces of evil, hatred, injustice, tyranny, betrayal and falsehood prevailing over justice, mercy, loyalty, goodness and truth" (S. M. Jafri, xii). In the soul, psyche and heart of the flawed yet mystically inclined believer, there is a constant battle between the heroic higher self and lower self (*nafs al ammara bil su*). The struggle against outward tyranny and injustice is reflected in the tyranny and injustice their *nafs* commits against their soul. Such transgressions are committed by distancing the human heart from the remembrance, fear, love and awareness of God. Such acts also take humans away from their primal and only purpose: to worship God (*ibadaha*) as His ever-striving servants (*Ubaid*) (Nasr 2011, 10).

For Jafri, the *Sahifah* "must be read against this background of man's crises at the personal and individual level" (S. M. Jafri, xii). According to him, the modern world's emphasis on materiality and exotericism has led to "exploitation", "terrible blindness", and "affliction" (S. M. Jafri, xi). Wherein the "exclusion" of "spirituality" has increased personal struggles and "oppressions" (S. M. Jafri, xii). In such circumstances, the *Sahifah* must be recognised as one of the most vital mystical treatises available today. It offers guidance and insight into the human condition – whilst providing spiritual nourishment for those seeking to break from their false realities and journey to the Ultimate Reality.

The infallible Imam and supplication

From a superficial glance, Al-Sajjad's role as an infallible Imam seeking forgiveness for his sins may seem incongruous. Constance says that the *Sahifah* is marked "... by a deep humility and sense of sin..." (Constance, xvi). While humility is a hallmark of piety in Islam, the above section on *walayah* outlines the Imams' un-sinning nature and perfection of servitude in lieu of Shi'ite and Sufi hagiographies of Prophets and Imams. Yet in the *Sahifah* Al-Sajjad:

"... often asks Allah for success in repentance which may be defined as turning towards Allah through acts of obedience and avoiding disobedience" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii).

In Islamic spirituality, there are "three basic" and "distinguished" levels for "every positive human quality", such as repentance (*tawbah*) and asking for forgiveness (*isteghfaar*) (Chittick 1988, xxxiii). For those who believe in the Imams' infallibility doctrine (*ismah*), their repentance, seeking forgiveness, repenting sins and heedlessness are not contradictory. Instead, they highlight the role of the Imam as the leader of the *ummah*. The Imams guide their followers through various stages of their flawed servitude – by virtue of the Imam's perfected servitude to Allah.

Not all supplications in the *Sahifah* apply to Al-Sajjad's own context and life. Chittick suggests that "some if not most" (Chittick 1988, xxvii) of the supplications in the *Sahifah* were written keeping his followers rather than himself in mind. Such as 'His supplication for his Parents' as he was orphaned after Karbala and 'His supplication in acts of wrongdoing' as an Imam is understood to be sinless by the Twelve *Imams* themselves. Such repentance is seen as "the first level", which belongs to "general" believers and "pertains to the activities governed by *Shariah*" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii). Such believers seek Allah's

pardon for "any act of commission or omission which is contrary to the *Shariah*" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii).

The "second level of repentance" is reserved for those who are "careful" in "observing *Shariah*" and "following recommended acts of the *sunna*" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii). They are called "the pious" and "repent the heedlessness (*ghafla*) of their soul" as they "do not sin" as per *Shariah*" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii). Al-Sajjad keeps both types of believers in mind for most of the supplications. While such reasoning is sufficient for devout Shi'ites and Sufis, there may need to be more for those who do not believe in the doctrine of Prophetic and *Imami* infallibility. Chittick aptly describes the conundrum:

“We have one of the greatest spiritual luminaries of Islam so overawed by the sense of Allah’s goodness, mercy, majesty as to express his utter nothingness before the Creator in terms that may seem surprisingly explicit for one deemed by his followers to be the possessor of such holiness” (Chittick 1988, xxviii).

Here, a closer introspection of the complex and intricate doctrine of infallibility (*ismah*) is required, keeping in mind the discussion on *walayah* as bestowed upon Allah's favoured creations to guide believers and foster more meaningful relations with the Divine.

Al-Sajjad defines an infallible (*masum*) as one "who clings to the cord of Allah. The cord of Allah and the Quran do not separate from each other till the day of resurrection." (Al-Qarashi, 88). The act or duty of 'clinging' requires persistent and continuous resilience in action, intention and spirit. At the same time, Allah inspires his chosen spiritual leader (*maula*), The Twelve, who foster infallibility as a privilege through their devotion and steadfastness in worshipping Allah. Their knowledge of, love for and proximity with the Divine fosters such infallibility. In Al-Qarashi's opinion, Allah does not make it impossible for the Imam to sin. Instead, it is their "firm faith" and piety" that "prevents them from

committing any sin" (Al-Qarashi, 89). The *Imams* and Prophets represent "the third level of repentance" of "those brought near to Allah" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii). Their inward and outward states are sinless "... since they see nothing but Allah's will, guidance, and mercy in every act and thought" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii).

Tawbah and Taqwah

However, perfection of servitude does not turn one into The Master. Prophets and Imams can never be characterised as "evil" (Chittick 1988, xxxi) in comparison to Allah as the Only Good, just as 'lesser good' in relation to Allah (Chittick 1988, xxxi). Just as the Imams cling to the cord of Allah, they also "cling to the differences" between themselves and Allah by their "servanthood" and "inadequacy" (Chittick 1988, xxxiii) in relation to Allah.

However, this is not in comparison or relation to other creations whom they have been sent to guide and lead. Since the Prophets and *Imams* have divinely bestowed knowledge of Allah's Nature, they "repent of their own inadequacies as creatures and ask forgiveness for their existence as separate beings" (Chittick 1988, xxxiv). Indeed, as Chittick says, the Prophet is "first ... His servant (*abdohu*) and then His messenger (*rasoolohu*)" (Chittick 1988, xxxii). He further states that even the Prophet "must first actualise the fullness of his own servanthood before he can hope to manifest anything on behalf of his Lord" (Chittick 1988, xxxii). Hence, no creation, after realising the inadequacies of their created nature, can "reach a point" where they "no longer need Allah's forgiveness" (Chittick 1988, xxxii).

Most importantly, the Arabic terms *tawbah* and *isteghfaar* have broader meanings than just repenting or asking for forgiveness. The term *tawbah* in the human condition "literally means to 'turn' or 'return' from one thing to another" (Chittick 1988, xxxiv). Similarly, one

of Allah's *Asma al-Husna* is 'At-Tawwab', meaning 'He who turns', and Allah also turns towards humans just as one turns towards Allah. "Man's repentance (*tawbah*) refers to every level of turning away from the self towards Allah" (Chittick 1988, xxxiv). Similarly, the term *maghferah* "in Arabic is far richer than the term 'forgiveness' in English", and three of Allah's Quranic names, *Al-Ghafoor*, *Al-Ghaafir* and *Al-Ghaffaar* are related to different levels of Allah's forgiveness (Chittick 1988, xxxiv). The root word means "to cover or conceal", so Allah as "the Forgiver is He who veils human sins and inadequacies" (Chittick 1988, xxxv). when they turn to him.

The last verse of 'His Supplication Upon Hearing Thunder' is the Quranic verse (2:285) regarding humanity's return to Allah and is one of the "most often recited and memorised passages of the Quran" (Nasr 2015, 305) coupled with the first line of verse (2:286). "The return to God" is one of the "five fundamental articles of Islamic faith" (Nasr 2015, 305). Hence, before the 'Day of Resurrection' and humanity's eventual return to Allah through death, believers are advised to turn to Allah before they return to Allah. In the temporal world, human beings still have a chance of repentance through their free will, which is to say, turning to Allah before they are returned to Allah through His Power of taking and giving life.

In various parts of the *Sahifah*, sin is often accompanied by a God-fearing attitude (*Taqwa*). The question arises: why do those chosen by Allah for love, proximity and friendship fear Him? The Quran answers it by saying, "Only those of His servants fear Allah who have knowledge" [35:28]. Such fear is not of wrath [*ghazab*] per se but rather awe-inspired by Allah's greatness, independence, and infiniteness compared to creation's flawed, dependent, and limited existence. As the 'Whispered Prayers of the Lovers' and the

'Whispered Prayers of the Knowers' highlight, there is a fear of losing Allah's "nearness", "friendship", "affection" and "true knowledge" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 248) rather than incurring vengeance or wrath. For devout believers, Allah's nearness, friendship, affection and knowledge are the highest spiritual privileges humans can attain. As the subsequent section on Allah's overwhelming Mercy highlights, there is minimal reference to Allah's wrath, vengeance or anger in the *Sahifah* compared to Allah's Mercy, Forgiveness and Generosity.

It is also said that those closest to Allah are the most God-fearing as "they have grasped the infinite distance that separates their created nature from their Creator" (Chittick 1988, xxxii). By understanding their created-ness and Allah's Allah-ness, "they are the most intense in devotion to Him since they see that only through devotion and worship can they fulfil His claims upon them" (Chittick 1988, xxxii). Additionally, Chittick says that:

"Most people may understand that they are asking Allah to conceal their 'sins', but 'those brought near to Allah' will see that they have the need for the concealment of something much deeper and radical since it is inherent to every created thing" (Chittick 1988, xxxv).

Despite not sinning or possessing human flaws like other creations, the infallible (*masumeen*) are even more embroiled in their love, worship and God-fearing attitudes. In the context of the *Sahifah*, when sinfulness is expressed, repenting, or asking for forgiveness, the infallibility of the Imams is conceptualised through their piety, steadfastness in worship, and perfection of servanthood.

The Quran and the Sahifah

After assessing the role and authority of Quranic interpretation vested in the Twelve Imams by the Shi'ite tradition, this paper will now move forward into understanding the attribute of the *Sahifah* as the sister of the Quran in light of the thematic and stylistic framework of the *Sahifah* and the Quran as mosaic texts.

Mosaic texts

The Quran is thematicized and stylised as a mosaic. According to Al-Ghazzali (d.1111 A.D), "... the Quranic style makes use of the interchange and blending of ideas, metaphors, and images within the same coherent context" (AlGhazzali, 142). He further states that the Quran: "is not made up of clearly defined or conventionally structured sentences and passage" (AlGhazzali, 142). Instead:

"The Quranic style and approach reflect the diversified, complex, and intricate yet essentially unified nature of the world around us. It is a world made up of millions of elements encompassing an unlimited number of manifestations, themes, and images" (AlGhazzali, 142).

While the Quran is The Divinely revealed book representing the Divine Mosaic, the *Sahifah* is a divinely inspired book representing a divinely inspired mosaic. Whatever the condition of the believer or external happening – the spirituality in the *Sahifah*' expresses in the most universal of languages, [a] concrete and intimate yearning of the soul for completion and perfection' (Chittick 1988, xxvii) in worship and servitude.

The mosaic nature of the *Sahifah* allows one to correspond the fragments of human life with the Names and Attributes of Allah. As 'the worshipper moves from one viewpoint to viewpoint, in keeping with the different relationships which exist between himself and Allah as described in the Quran' (Chittick 1988, xl). The *Sahifah* directly references eight Quranic verses (2:286, 3:106, 2:152, 6:160, 9:33, 80:20, 81:21 and 89:15) which outline the relationship between Allah and humankind²⁰. Every supplication or whispered prayer is within the framework of a human's relationship with God. This relationship in the *Sahifah* is in light of the ever-pervasive Presence of the Ultimate Reality, which encapsulates all aspects of the individual's life.

For example, Allah is described as the Refuge in 'His supplication in Seeking Refuge' (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 138). In 'His supplication for Help in Repaying Debt', Allah is portrayed as The Provider (*Al-Raziq*) (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 105). In the supplication for those finishing a Quran, Allah is depicted as The Knower (*Al-Alim*) who spread his Knowledge through His Book (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 136). By referring to different Names and Attributes of Allah, the believer can place himself firmly in the relationship with Allah, as is evident in the 'Supplication for Tuesday' in which Al-Sajjad quotes verses of the Quran to emphasise the importance of having a multifaceted relationship with Allah's Infinite facets. In this prayer, Al-Sajjad prays to be one of Allah's "troops"; as per 37:173 "they are the victors" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 225). He prays to be part of Allah's "party" as per 58:22 "they are the ones who prosper" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 225) and to be "among Thy (Allah's) "friends" as per 10:62 "... no fear shall be upon them, nor shall they sorrow" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 226). In this light "man's point of view changes because each of the divine names points to a different

²⁰ Table 5(b).

face of Allah turned toward him. Yet all are Faces of Allah" (Chittick 1988, xl), and the proof texts for this multifaceted relationship pointing to the Singular point are taken from the Quran itself. Through this format, the *Sahifah* emphasises an "overwhelming ... Allah-centeredness ... which is given concrete form by the *Shariah* and the *sunnah*" (Chittick 1988, xxxvii).

There is also a mosaic of various sub-themes, images and motifs within each supplication, just as one Quranic verse can contain more than one theme. While Padwick acknowledges the individuality of Al-Sajjad in the *Sahifah*, for her, "the mosaic quality" of most Muslim supplications consists of "well-tried small items arranged in ever new patterns – traditional prayers of the Prophet, Quranic verses, blessings on the Prophet, forgiveness seeking, cries of praise, all on known authorised forms" (Chittick 1988, xxxix). However, as Chittick contends, this mosaic quality is itself a reflection of the Quran, "which is a mosaic of Allah's names and activities, stories of the prophets, legal injunctions, and promises and warnings about the Last Day" (Chittick 1988, xxxix).

Neither Constance nor Chittick contest Al-Sajjad's undeniable individuality, which has lent the *Sahifah* the quality of being a mirror of Divine Unity reflected through Al-Sajjad's divinely inspired soul. Similarly, Nasr says that "the substance of the soul of a Muslim ... is like a mosaic made up of the imprint of verses of the Quran upon that human substance" (Nasr, Introduction 2015, 33). Hence, just as the believing individual's soul moves through various fragments of the Quran, the *Sahifah* moves alongside it – guiding and moulding the soul in accordance with the Divine Will.

Al-Sajjad's curated mosaic

The *Sahifah* is a systematic prayer manual, with supplications chronologized and organised by Al-Sajjad himself. At a glance, the titles of the supplications reveal a crucial aspect of the book, which is in contrast to the contents of the supplications. The supplications are in themselves undeniably Allah-centric – not to say that human nature is not thoroughly and eloquently discussed. The contents of the supplications direct believers to engage with various aspects of Allah's Divinity and multiple states within themselves. Such engagement helps believers construct a relationship between different human states and different Attributes of Allah.

The titles are predominantly human-centric, inviting believers to use their various socio-familial and psycho-spiritual conditions as a starting point in loving, knowing and worshipping Allah. As Chittick aptly states, "the *Sahifah* typifies supplication as the constant exercise between attributing what belongs to Allah to Allah, and what belongs to man to man" (Chittick 1988, xxix). Just as the text demonstrates an intimate, complex and sophisticated understanding of the Divine, it also "shows a remarkable awareness of the depth of human imperfection" (Chittick 1988, xl). This profound and divinely bestowed insight into the human *fitrah* led Al-Sajjad to focus on various human conditions as a starting point for guiding his followers out of their sinfulness and into Allah's Mercy. In Shi'ism, fostering the aspiration to journey from imperfect states to loftier stations is the duty of the Imam and *Wali*. The fostering and nurturing of such aspirations is characteristic of the *Sahifah* as a mystical treatise.

Theological concerns

The remarkable scope of the *Sahifah* can be determined just through the titles of the supplications (Ali ibn al-Husayn, v-vii). Supplications 1, 55, and 56 are exclusively related to praising and glorifying Allah²¹. While this research will explore Allah's Nature in the *Sahifah* in greater detail later, it is essential to note the thematic correspondence of supplications to the Quran. Praising Allah (*Alhamdulillah*) is the second verse of the first surah (Al-Fatiha) after the *basmallah* (which is considered the first verse of all Quranic Surahs in many Islamic traditions) in the Quran. Just as the first supplication is titled 'Praise of God'. In total, fifteen supplications in the *Sahifah* begin with praising Allah²², while two supplications (1 and 22) end with praising Allah²³. Quranic verses praising Allah, such as 1:2 and 35:15, occur once each in the *Sahifah* in supplication 47 and 13, respectively²⁴.

Prophets

Five supplications (2, 3, 4, 57 and 58)²⁵ are dedicated to Allah's chosen creations – such as 'Blessing upon the Prophet', Blessings on the Followers and Attesters to Prophets' and 'His Supplication in Mentioning the Household of Muhammad'. However, it is imperative to point out that apart from the family of the Prophet (*ahle bait*), the *Sahifah* also engages with other Prophets and divinely ordained creatures such as angels. 'His supplication in Calling down Blessings upon Adam' and 'Blessing upon the Bearers of the Throne' are examples of supplications dedicated to sending blessings upon Allah's divinely ordained creatures.

²¹ Table 1.

²² Table 2.

²³ Table 3.

²⁴ Table 4.

²⁵ Table 1.

There are five Quranic references to Prophets, Prophetic stories and prayers²⁶. Verse 11:56 is referenced twice in Supplication 21 and 23, which talks about Prophet Hudd and his followers whom Allah's Mercy saved. Verse 28:35, alluded to once in supplication 47, refers to Allah's promise to Prophet Musa and Haroon about their imminent victory against Pharoah. Verse 57:25, referenced once in supplication 42, concerns Allah sending "messengers with clear proofs" – which is to say that the Quran confirms the authority of Prophethood itself. Verse 58:22, referenced once in supplication 64, makes it clear that opposing Allah's Messengers is akin to opposing Allah Himself, once again emphasising the importance of Prophets. Quranic verses that outline prayers by Prophet Musa, Abraham, etc., such as 11:40 and 11:80, are alluded to once each. While 7:151 is referenced thrice, 20:31 and 26:84 are directly referred to once each – all of them are verses of Prophetic prayers in the Quran²⁷. Additionally, six supplications focus on socio-familial relations (5, 24, 25, 26, 27 and 35) such as 'His Supplication for his Children', 'His Prayer for Parents' and 'His Supplication for Neighbours and Friends'²⁸.

Jurisprudence

There are thirteen supplications (42, 44, 45, 46, 47, 48, 62, 63, 64, 65, 66, 67 and 68) about Islamic rites, *Shariah* injunctions and important days such as 'His Supplication for the Coming of the Month of Ramadan'; 'His Supplication on the Day of Fast-Breaking and Friday'; 'His Supplication on the Day of Sacrifice and Friday' amongst others²⁹. According to Nasr, the "Quran is the fundamental source of Islamic Law". At the same time, Allah is

²⁶ Table 5(c).

²⁷ Table 5(c).

²⁸ Table 1.

²⁹ Table 1.

considered the "Ultimate Legislator" as per his Name, The Legislator (*Al-Shari*) and "Divine Law is the concrete embodiment of Divine Will" (Nasr 2015, 22). Furthermore, "a few hundred Quranic verses deal in a concrete manner with law while others deal with principles upon which revealed laws are based" (Nasr 2015, 22).

Eight Quranic verses that deal with *shariah*, *fiqh*, and legal matters have been mentioned in the *Sahifah*³⁰ 2:185 and are directly referenced twice in supplication 42 and 44³¹. Verses 2:222, 22:78, 23:60, 25:68, 33:33 and 33:52 are referenced once in supplication 31, 66, 44, 32, 47 and 47 respectively³². Referencing verses that deal with *shariah* and legal injunctions in a metaphysical book represent the all-encompassing nature of the *Sahifah*'s spirituality and adherence to Divine Will. According to Nasr:

“the *shariah* is the circumference of a circle whose radii are the *turaq* (plural of *tariqah*) and whose centre is the *Haqiqah* or Truth, that is the Source of both the Law and the Way as well as the Centre for one who begins on the circumference, journeys along one of the radii, and finally reaches the Centre...” (Nasr 2011, 5).

Hence, the *Sahifah* and Al-Sajjad present the complete way of accessing Allah, which encapsulates both *shariah* injunctions and spiritual path (*tariqah*), representing the balance between the exoteric and esoteric aspects of the Quran and Islam.

Nature and the Cosmos

Just as the Quran has "extensive teachings about cosmogenesis, cosmic history ... and the Quran refers to these phenomena as signs (*ayats*)" (Nasr, Introduction 2015, 21), the *Sahifah* emphasizes the cosmos and nature by dedicating six supplications (no 6, 19, 32,

³⁰ Table 5(c).

³¹ Table 4.

³² Table 4.

36, 40 and 43) to them³³. Supplications for engaging with the cosmos/nature include: 'His Supplication upon looking at the Crescent Moon', 'His supplication upon Hearing Thunder', 'His supplication in Asking for Water' and others. Similarly, six supplications begin with verses proclaiming various natural and cosmological phenomena as signs of Divine Will (no. 48, 43, 19, 3, 42 and 36)³⁴. The emphasis in the Quran on nature and the cosmos is adequately referenced in the *Sahifah*, with thirteen Quranic verses detailing these phenomena. 14:33, 15:21, 15:22, 10:67, 14:33, 17:12, 25:47, 97:5 and 113:1 are all mentioned directly once in supplication 1,47, 47, 6, 1, 6, 65, 44 and 54, respectively. Additionally, verses 13:13 and 6:96 are alluded to once in supplication 27 and 6, respectively³⁵.

The psycho-spiritual

However, as stated above, most supplication titles refer to the human condition, wherein more negative socio-psycho-spiritual states are addressed than positive ones. Twelve supplications are outlining positive psycho-spiritual states (18, 37, 39, 72, 74, 75, 76 and 77)³⁶ which include 'The Whispered prayers of the Thankful'; 'The Whispered prayers of the Devotees'; 'His Supplication in seeking Pardon and Mercy'; 'His Supplication when Perils were repelled or Requests Quickly Granted'; 'The Whispered prayer of the Obedient' and others. Seven supplications (11, 13, 20, 23, 30, 73 and 78)³⁷ outline positive personal aspirations such as 'His supplication in Asking for the Best'; 'His Supplication in Seeking Good Outcomes'; 'His Supplication in asking Allah for Well-Being' and the 'Whispered

³³ Table 1.

³⁴ Table 2.

³⁵ Table 4.

³⁶ Table 1.

³⁷ Table 1.

Prayer of the Hopeful' alongside others. These positive states, or aspirations towards positivity, are also reflected in the mosaic of human nature and spirituality as presented in the Quran.

Certain Quranic verses outlining positive characteristics of psycho-spiritual states are also referenced in the *Sahifah*. Which shows how intricately related the mosaic of the Quran and *Sahifah* are to each other. For example, the *Sahifah* quotes three verses (25:70, 45:21 and 65:11) of the Quran about 'righteous' believers. Similarly, two Quranic references (15:40 and 38:83) describe the 'sincere'³⁸. Four Quranic verses (53:31, 9:100, 17:7 and 29:69) quoted in the *Sahifah* describe the 'virtuous'. Three Quranic verses (42:25, 12:222 and 9:104) reference 'those who repent', while two references (13:34 and 18:28) speak of 'the patient ones'³⁹. Al-Sajjad also references Quranic verses outlining 'those two purify themselves' twice (2:222 and 33:33)⁴⁰ and 'those who strive for God' five times (5:48, 22:78, 29:69, 18:28 and 2:261)⁴¹.

The predominant category is for various ailments and afflictions. Four supplications outline socio-personal ailments (4, 30, 34 and 49)⁴², such as his supplication for 'repaying debt' and 'repelling the trickery of enemies'. Eight supplications focus on personal adverse ailments (7, 15, 21, 22, 29, 41, 54 and 60)⁴³, such as 'His supplication for when provision was stinted', His supplication when sick', etc. Lastly, eighteen supplication titles focus on negative psycho-spiritual states (8, 9, 10, 12, 16, 17, 28, 31, 34, 38, 50, 51, 53, 59, 61, 69,

³⁸ Table 5(b).

³⁹ Table 5(b).

⁴⁰ Table 5(b).

⁴¹ Table 5(b).

⁴² Table 1.

⁴³ Table 1.

70, 71 and 79)⁴⁴ such as 'The Whispered Prayer of the Fearful'; 'The Whispered Prayer of the Complainers'; 'His Supplication in Pleading and Abasement'; 'His Supplication in seeking Refuge from Hateful things'; 'His Supplication in asking Release from sins and seeking Pardon'; 'His Supplication in Distress and Seeking Release' and 'His Supplication against that which he Feared and Dreaded' amongst others.

However – as this paper seeks to demonstrate, every human imperfection – is met with overwhelming Mercy from Allah within the contents of the supplications. For example, this research categorises repentance as a negative psycho-spiritual state as it stems from the human condition of sin. After engaging in the prescribed spiritual exercise of repentance, the negativity of sin is met with Allah's Mercy and Forgiveness, which transforms the sinner's negative state into a positive state of one who has been purified of their sins.

Analysis of mosaic themes and stylistics

The purpose of looking at various human conditions, doctrines and articles of faith present in the *Sahifah* through their frequency of occurrence and inclusion of supporting Quranic verses – is to emphasise on the intricate yet expansive scope of the *Sahifah's* thematic concerns. Moreover, it highlights the *Sahifah's* thematic correspondence with the Quran, wherein the *Sahifah* replicates and expands upon Quranic concepts. Through a quantitative and qualitative analysis of the *Sahifah's* mosaic correspondence to the mosaic of the Quran – Allah's overwhelmingly Mercy in both texts becomes evident.

⁴⁴ Table 1.

Moreover, by placing the mosaic of the *Sahifah* and the Quran within the context of various positive and negative psycho-spiritual, nature-cosmos, and socio-familial contexts – one can grasp the mosaic of positive and negative qualities present within human nature. By aligning each state to a specific feature of Allah's Nature and contextualising these states within Allah's overwhelming Mercy, believers can actualise aspects of Divine Mercy within themselves across various external and internal conditions.

Allah's Nature: Divine Unity and Infinite Mercy

As the above section outlines, many Quranic thematic concerns and doctrines are elaborated in the *Sahifah*. One of the most prominent overarching themes in both these texts is the Divine Unity of Allah (*Tawheed*), known through His *Asmat al-Husna*, precisely His Overwhelmingly Merciful Nature. Divine Unity is mentioned thrice in the *Sahifah* while "professing to" or witnessing it is mentioned eight times (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 300). This section will analyse how Divine Nature is depicted in the *Sahifah* and how the *Sahifah* draws upon and corresponds with the Quranic understanding of Allah's Nature. According to Chittick, "... the Allah of the Quran is predominantly an Allah of mercy and tenderness, an Allah of intimacy and concern" (Chittick 1988, xxxvi), which is "... a constant theme in the *Sahifah*" (Chittick 1988, xxxviii). While this section will not focus on Allah's overwhelming Mercy in the Quran, it will focus on the overwhelmingly Merciful depiction of Allah present in the *Sahifah* via the Quran and Al-Sajjad's personal understanding of Allah's Nature as per His Most Beautiful Names and Attributes.

Asma-al-Husna wal-Siffat

Knowledge of and love for Allah and His Nature are considered as the two cornerstones of piety and devotion in worship. Accessing His Mercy increases the proximity between creation and the Creator and brings believers closer to The Ultimate Reality. According to a *hadith al-qudsi*, Allah outlines the importance of love and knowledge in His reasoning for creation: "I was a Hidden Treasure, and I loved to be known. Therefore I created the world so I would be known" (Nasr 2011, 18). As for the process of creation, mystics believe "that God breathed His Goodness, which is also Mercy and through this 'Breath of the Compassionate or the Infinitely Good' (*nafas al-Rahman*) the world came into being"

(Nasr 2011, 15). *Al-Rahman* is also a Name of Attribute of Allah outlining His Mercy, Compassion and Goodness, as this section will subsequently explore.

One of the most important ways of understanding Allah and the Divine Unity of His Nature is through His *Asma al-Husna*. The Quran states that "The most beautiful Names belong to God, so call Him by them" (7:180; cf. 17:110; 20:8; 59:24). Chittick contends that:

"All the words of the Quran are God's words, but the most fundamental are His names. In Islamic theology, both scholastic and mystical, there is a great commentary upon the names of God, which reveal His nature to mankind" (Chittick 2011, 121).

In all the Names, "Allah is the supreme or all-comprehensive name since it refers to God's very Self; other names mentioned in the Quran and Hadith are subordinate to it" (Chittick 2011, 122). Despite being the most common and often invoked Name in the Islamic tradition, the term 'Allah' also denotes the Transcendent, Sublime Nature of the Divine.

Al-Sajjad creates proximity and intimacy with even the most awe-inspiring Name by constantly referring to Allah as 'my Allah' (*Illahi*). Twelve supplications that begin with the invocation of '*Illahi*'⁴⁵ such as 'His Supplication in Pleading and Abasement'; 'The Whispered Prayer of the Remembers', 'The Whispered Prayer of those asking for Mediation', and others. The term is replete throughout the text, especially in the whispered prayers. For example, the 'Whispered Prayer of the Thankful Al-Sajjad says: "My Allah, the uninterrupted flow of Thy graciousness hast distracted me from thanking Thee!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 242). In the 'Whispered Prayer of the Repenters', all verses except the second verse begin with the term '*Illahi*' (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 232-4). Al-Sajjad successfully bridges the distance between The Divine and His creation by aligning the possessive term 'my' to Allah – placing Allah's Transcendence and Sublimity squarely within the one-on-

⁴⁵ Table 2.

one relationship. This makes Allah a personal God, One whose Being cannot be related to but whom a believer can still claim as 'mine'.

In the introduction to the Study Quran, Nasr maintains that:

"The Quran reveals a galaxy of Divine Names and Qualities, which by virtue of being revealed are sacred and provide the means of not only knowing God but also of returning to Him. They thus play a central role not only in Islamic metaphysics and theology but also in the practical and ritual aspects of Islamic religious and spiritual life" (Nasr 2015, 21).

Nasr further says that metaphysics relies primarily on the *Asma al-Husna wal Siffat* (The Divine Names, Qualities and Attributes) as revealed in the Quran by Allah (Nasr 2011, 36). These 99 names are present throughout the Quran and provide an understanding of the Divine Essence of Allah, who facilitates believers through knowledge of Himself in the Quran. These Names and Qualities of Allah are directly related to Allah's Essence (*al-Dhat*), which is beyond human comprehension and determination. However, the Names and Qualities of Allah are "the first Self-Determinations or Self-Entifications of the Essence" (Nasr 2011, 36). For example, since Allah is Essentially Generosity (*Karamah*), His name is The Generous (*Al-Karim*) and His actions (*al-Af'al*) are subsequently always marked by His Essential and Qualitative Identifiable Generosity. Nasr contends that calling Allah by His "Beautiful Names" or using "Quranic terminology" to access the Divine "results in receiving His answer since He Himself has revealed these Names as His Names; it results in drawing nigh into Him" (Nasr 2011, 36).

Drawing upon the *hadith al-qudsi* quoted upon, Nasr further states that:

"The purpose of creation is God's Self Knowledge through Self-Manifestation and Self-Disclosure. This Self-Disclosure is made possible through the reflections of God's Names and Qualities (Nasr 2011, 43).

Divine Nature in the *Sahifah*

Reflecting upon Allah's *Asma al-Husna* in the *Sahifah*, Chittick contends that "the Imam [Al-Sajjad] constantly recurses to Allah's names", which outlines "the connection between the spiritual attitudes expressed in the *Sahifah* and the Quranic statements about Allah" (Chittick 1988, xxxvii). Indeed, one of the most predominant concerns of the *Sahifah* is outlining Allah's Nature and aligning "... an appropriate expression of the corresponding human attitude" (Chittick 1988, xxxvii).

Al-Sajjad also recurrently focuses upon an exciting interplay of the Ultimate Reality of Allah and His Divine Names and Attributes— by employing variations of the Islamic testimony of faith (*shahadah*). The testimony of faith, which proclaims that "There is no allah but Allah", is found in the Quran (37:35; 47:19). Nasr calls it "the supreme statement concerning Divine Unity and Transcendence" (Nasr 2015, 21), while Chittick refers to it as "the essence of the Quranic message" (Chittick 1988, xxix). Chittick further says that "the *Sahifah* provides a particularly striking example of what this [the *shahadah*] means in personal, practical terms not in the abstract language of theology or metaphysics" (Chittick 1988, xxix). The *Sahifah* takes various attributes and "places it within the context of the *shahadah*: There is no goodness, but in Allah, There is no knowledge but in Allah" (Chittick 1988, xxix). Nasr defines this act as:

"... Reintegrating all positive qualities back into the One. The *shahadah* also means that there is ultimately no beauty but the Divine Beauty, no goodness but the Divine Goodness, no power but the Divine Power and so on. Metaphysically, it means that there is ultimately no reality but the Divine Reality" (Nasr 2015, 21).

Since the *Sahifah* is the direct communication between a believer and Allah, this *shahadah* is aligned with helping believers understand Allah's Nature through their own nature and, in turn, helping believers understand their own human nature. Chittick refers to this as the

Sahifah's quality of "typifying supplication as the constant exercise between attributing what belongs to Allah to Allah, and what belongs to man to man" (Chittick 1988, xxix).

In this light, the elaborated *shahadah* in the *Sahifah*, through its emphasis not only on the Oneness of Allah's Divine Reality but also on the Unity of Being, becomes a practice through which the believer can actualize "that the worshipper is nothing and Allah is all" (Chittick 1988, xxix). On one end means attributing all positivity, human or divine, to Allah, "There is no repentance, but by Allah's grace, there is no patience without Allah's help" (Chittick 1988, xxix). On the other end, it also means to reallocate "every fault and imperfection ... to the servant's own specific attributes" (Chittick 1988, xxix), which is to say "if he has patience in adversity, this was given by Allah, but if he lacks it, this is his own shortcoming" (Chittick 1988, xxix) and so on.

According to Chittick, "Only when this fact shapes a person's imagination and awareness can he begin to see things in their right proportions and be delivered from his own self-deceptions" (Chittick 1988, xxix). Through Al-Sajjad's navigation of the relationship between believers and the Created, we understand Allah's Nature through the Quran. Additionally, the *Sahifah* demonstrates how His Nature shapes human nature and how human nature can align itself with the 99 Attributes of Allah and Allah as the Ultimate and Only Reality. This emphasis is reflected in the frequency of referencing, describing and explaining various Attributes and Qualities of Allah throughout the *Sahifah*.⁴⁶ As the above section shows, the titles of the supplications are human-centric to attract believers in various psycho-spiritual and socio-economic conditions. However, the contents of the

⁴⁶ Tables 5(a) and 6.

supplication are focused on the specific Attributes of Allah's Nature that believers need to align themselves with to actualize the Divine through their specific human state.

However, there are still three supplications dedicated to Allah's Nature (1, 55 and 56)⁴⁷. There are 46 supplications whose beginning verses describe or call upon specific Attributes of Allah's nature⁴⁸, while 46 supplications end on the same note⁴⁹. Out of 84, the most predominant theme in the beginning and ending verses of all the supplications is Divine Nature. Similarly, out of 316 Quranic references and allusions, 117 verses are about Allah's Nature⁵⁰. Given the qualitative and quantitative emphasis on Allah's Nature through the Quran in the *Sahifah* and elaborations upon descriptions of various attributes by Al-Sajjad – it is clear that the *Sahifah* is predominately concerned with understanding and knowing Allah's Nature, especially His Mercy, Compassion and Forgiveness.

Asma al-Husna in the Sahifah

Before moving on to the *Sahifah's* depiction of Allah's overwhelming Mercy, examining how other attributes and qualities are elaborated upon in the text is imperative. The Islamic tradition has a few methods for categorizing the *Asma al-Husna*. Nasr explains one such method derived from the "... duality [of] the archetype of the feminine/masculine" (Nasr 2011, 37). "The Names are divided into those of Majesty (*Jalal*), the source of the masculine, and those of Beauty (*Jamal*), the source of the feminine" (Nasr 2011, 37). Chittick explains another method employed by "Muslim thinkers" who categorize the names in "two broad categories" with "contrasting attributes such as wrath (*ghazab*) and

⁴⁷ Table 1.

⁴⁸ Table 2.

⁴⁹ Table 3.

⁵⁰ Table 5(a).

mercy (*rahma*), justice (*adl*) and bounty (*fazl*), severity (*qahr*) and gentleness (*lutf*)” (Chittick 1988, xxxv) and so on.

While the *Sahifah* addresses both categories through both methodologies, there is a clear emphasis on Divine Nature's Merciful, Generous and Compassionate aspects. Nasr maintains that "the Quran contains above all a doctrine about the nature of reality on all its levels from Absolute Reality Itself, that is, the One God to the reality of creation both microcosmic and macrocosmic" (Nasr 2015, 20). In light of the various levels of reality and dualities existing within the Singular Ultimate Reality, the Divine is “at one impersonal and personal, transcendent and immanent, majestic and beautiful” (Nasr 2015, 20).

Chittick presents a similar analysis in the Introduction to the *Sahifah*: "There is no contradiction between thinking of Allah as transcendent and perceiving Him as immanent" as "Allah reveals Himself under a variety of guises [which] demand different rational perceptions and psychological responses” (Chittick 1988, xxxvii). One of the aims of the *Sahifah* is to align varying human psycho-spiritual capacities to various Divine Qualities. Since "one cannot think in the same terms about The Glorified (*Al-Sabhooh*) who transcends everything that man can conceive, and The Near (*Al-Qareeb*) who is closer than the jugular vein” – The *Sahifah* acts as a mystical treatise and blueprint for a harmonious alignment of human perspective with the Divine. Chittick aptly observes that different ways of engaging with Allah's Nature “once codified and institutionalized ... came to emphasise certain divine attributes rather than others” (Chittick 1988, xxxviii).

One of the responses was from jurisprudence and theology in which “jurists and theologians lay stress on the Allah of remoteness and transcendence” (Chittick 1988, xxxv) due to their "disciplined, rational methodology [which addressed] intellectuals like

themselves" (Chittick 1988, xxxvi). Leading to "dry and abstract depictions" (Chittick 1988, xxxvi) of Allah as the "Commander and Lawgiver ... a Monarch [standing] far above his subjects" with a "just" (Chittick 2011, xxxviii), "stern and severe countenance" (Chittick 2011, xxxv). On the other hand, "Islamic spirituality and devotional literature put more stress on His Gentleness and Similarity" (Chittick 1988, xxxv) and a "particular characteristic ... [of] ... the *Sahifah* is to emphasise the personal quality of Allah's relationship with His servants and His all-pervading Love" (Chittick 1988, xxxviii).

The Quran, *hadith* and spiritual authorities provide descriptions of Allah, which are "warm and concrete", speaking "in a language that appeals to the imagination" and "bypassing reason [to appeal to] something far more universal in human hearts" (Chittick 1988, xxxvi). Chittick contends that spiritual authorities such as Al-Sajjad "emphasise the personal dimension of the human/Divine relationship. They stress Allah's nearness and immanence" since the "Allah of the Quran is pre-dominantly an Allah of mercy and tenderness, an Allah of intimacy and concern" (Chittick 1988, xxxv). Today, the *Sahifah* is mainly categorized as a spiritual response to Allah's Nature in the Quran; however, during Al-Sajjad's time, such codifications and institutionalization were uncommon. Chittick also contends, "In the early period, it is difficult to disentangle the different strands, since institutional forms which highlight them have not yet come into existence" (Chittick 1988, xxxviii).

Moreover, as the section on Al-Sajjad outlines, he was considered a leading jurist of the Umayyad era by friends and foes alike. Hence, it would be incorrect to categorize the *Sahifah* as either a spiritual or jurisprudential response, instead to look at it in light of Al-Sajjad's role as an Imam, *wali* and guide in the Shi'ite tradition. In this light, his role and response encompass all aspects of the Islamic tradition. The *Sahifah* encourages

engagement with Allah as the Divine Lawgiver and Divine source of Mercy in a way that entwines the two ideals for spiritual and temporal wayfaring. Such a wholesome approach is reflective of the Quranic influence on the *Sahifah*.

The overwhelmingly Merciful

There is an emphasis and proclivity to the Merciful aspects of the Divine in the *Sahifah* within this approach. The *Sahifah's* emphasis echoes the Quranic emphasis on Divine Mercy; in verse 7:156, Allah says, "My Mercy embraces all things". Chittick maintains that those who focus on Allah's Justice and Wrath "... tend to ignore the fact that practically every chapter of the Quran begins with the words, In the name of Allah, the All-Merciful, the All-Compassionate (Chittick 1988, xxxviii).

Similarly, a *hadith al-qudsi* describes Allah as The Sovereign (*Malik al-Mulk*) sitting atop the Divine Throne, which the Quran refers to *al-Kursi* and *al-Arsh* in Quranic verses such as 10:3 and 23:116. The *hadith* states that "written on the Divine Throne" are the words "Verily My Mercy precedes My Wrath" (Nasr 2011, 37). According to Nasr, "This *hadith* means that although God is just and is wrathful towards evildoers, His Mercy comes before His Justice, and He forgives those who have committed evil acts yet turn to Him..." (Nasr 2011, 37).

The *Sahifah* and sayings of Al-Sajjad echo the understanding of Allah's Mercy superseding His Wrath and His Forgiveness superseding His justice. When he heard:

"... Hasan al-Basri (d 110A.H/728 C.E), the famous ascetic, had said: 'It is not strange if a person perishes as he perishes. It is only strange that a person is saved as he is saved.' The Imam replied, 'But I say that it is not strange if a person is saved as he is saved; it is only strange that a person perishes as he perishes, given the scope of Allah's Mercy'" (Chittick 1988, xli).

In the *Sahifah*, Al-Sajjad says:

“Thou art He whose mercy runs before His wrath! ... Whose bestowal is greater than His withholding! ... By whose mercy all creatures are embraced!” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 56).

Hence, it is evident throughout the *Sahifah* and Al-Sajjad’s ethos on Divine Nature that while Wrath, Vengeance and Punishment are a part of Allah’s Nature, they are enveloped within His Mercy. So much so that even non-wrathful depictions of Allah, such as His Oneness, His Uniqueness and Eternal Nature, are encompassed by His Mercy. Herein, one of the predominant aims of the *Sahifah* can be seen: to guide believers out of psycho-spiritual states and actions which incur Allah’s wrath and vengeance and turn them towards Allah’s Mercy and Compassion. The *Sahifah* does not act as a mere warner or describer of Allah’s wrath and vengeance but rather as a teacher and guide, which turns believers away from wrath and into mercy.

The *Sahifah* paints a similar picture to the Quran, where Allah, in all His Majesty and Glory, is willing and eager to Help, Forgive and Give towards His worshippers. Such a depiction of Allah, placed squarely within the on-on-one dialogue between the Divine and creation, outlines an intimately close and intensely fulfilling relationship, wherein Divinity actively works towards human success, not failure. Before moving onto the concept of overwhelming Mercy, it is imperative to briefly discuss how Mercy envelopes other Qualities of Allah in the *Sahifah*. While the *Sahifah* includes all 99 *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat* throughout the supplications, this paper will briefly discuss how Allah’s Might, Sovereignty, Transcendence and Knowledge are portrayed in the light of His overwhelmingly Mercy rather than categorically contradictory to it.

Powerfully Merciful

Some of the most often invoked Attributes of Allah in the *Sahifah* are The All-Powerful (*Al-Muqtadir*) and The All-Mighty (*Al-Aziz*), which are often connected to Allah’s

Lordship (*Al-Malik*) and Sovereignty (*Al-Malik ul Mulk*). The most frequently referenced Quranic verse in the *Sahifah* is (3:26) found in supplication 6, 12, 16, 21, 31, 32 and 33⁵¹:

“O God, Master of Sovereignty. Thou givest sovereignty to whomsoever Thou wilt, and wrestest sovereignty from whomsoever Thou wilt. Thou exaltest whomsoever Thou wilt, and abasest whomsoever Thou wilt. In Thy Hand is the good. Truly Thou art Powerful over everything.”

The term ‘Thou art Powerful over everything’ is also the ending verse of 5 supplications such as ‘His Supplication for himself and the People under his Guardianship’, ‘His Supplication for Water during a Drought’, ‘His Supplication on Noble More Traits and Acts Pleasing to Allah’ and ‘His Supplication when Faced with a Worrisome Task or when Misfortune Descended and at the Time of Distress’⁵².

Apart from 3:26, Quranic verses 30:54 and 21:23, which speak about Allah's Power, are also quoted in the *Sahifah*.⁵³ The wide variety of human conditions concerning nature, other people, and positive and negative psycho-spiritual states shows the multi-faceted and overarching application of Allah's Power. Similarly, Allah is referred to as All-Mighty (*Al-Aziz*) from 7 different Quranic verses⁵⁴ and three supplications begin with talking about Allah's Might, such as 'His Supplication for himself and the People under his Guardianship' and 'His Supplication in Seeking Asylum with Allah'⁵⁵. While eight supplications in the *Sahifah* end on verses referring to Allah's Might and supplication, 67's ending verse refers to Allah's Might and Wisdom⁵⁶. Through the placement of Allah's Might throughout the text of the *Sahifah*, the one-on-one dialogue with Allah is conducted with the understanding

⁵¹ Table 4.

⁵² Table 3.

⁵³ Table 5(a).

⁵⁴ Table 5(a).

⁵⁵ Table 2.

⁵⁶ Table 3.

that Allah's Might dominates the entire universe, including the dialogue. Allah's Power and Might are then placed within the framework of Allah as *Al-Malik* (The Master) and *Al-Malik-ul-Mulk* (The Sovereign).

Within the same framework, humankind is depicted as "slaves" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 283) and "subjects" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 287). While this may invoke an image of distance, coldness and unreliability, the *Sahifah's* understanding and proliferation of the terms throughout the text, like the Quran, depict a Loving and Caring Master closely connected to His slaves and subjects. Six supplications end with verses referring to Allah's Lordship and Sovereignty.⁵⁷ while 13 Quranic verses describe Allah as *Al-Malik* and *Al-Malik ul Mulk*⁵⁸. Chittick contends that the *Sahifah's* treatment of Allah's Sovereignty and Lordship is like the Quran's; "the overwhelming Quranic picture is that of a Allah deeply concerned with the well-being of His creatures and ready to forgive almost anything, if only they will repent and acknowledge His Sovereignty" (Chittick 1988, xxxviii).

Just as the *Sahifah* elaborates and codifies Allah's role as the All-Encompassing (*Al-Waasi*) – through 5 Quranic allusions and references in supplication 16, 45 and 47⁵⁹ – it also establishes Allah as The Expander (*Al-Basit*) and The Withholder (*Al-Qaabid*) through verse 2:245 in 'His Supplication for Bidding Farewell to the month of Ramadan.'⁶⁰. Keeping in mind the Quranic verse 7:151, which speaks of Allah's Mercy encompassing everything, and the above discussion on Allah as The Most Powerful, All-Mighty, Master and Sovereign – it can be said that Al-Sajjad views The Divine as Mercifully All-Powerful, Mercifully Mightly, the Merciful Master and Sovereign. That is to say since Allah is the

⁵⁷ Table 3.

⁵⁸ Table 5 (a).

⁵⁹ Tables 4 and 5(a).

⁶⁰ Tables 4 and 5(a).

Sole Power, Might and Encompasser, He is also The Sole Withholder and Expander of His Power. Placing this within the *Sahifah's* framework of overwhelming Mercy – it can be said that Allah withholds His Wrath and Expands His Mercy. Even though His Mercy and Wrath are equally Powerful, since He chooses His Mercy to supersede His Wrath, His Mercy is empowered by His entire Sovereignty and Lordship. ‘The Whispered Prayers of the Beseechers’ is evidence of how Al-Sajjad implores Allah to withhold His Wrath and Expand His Mercy: “Act toward me with the forgiveness and mercy of which Thou art worthy! Act not towards me with the chastisement and vengeance of which I am worthy” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 242).

Mercifully Transcendent

The *Sahifah* also refers to *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*, which focus on Allah's Transcendental Nature, such as The Exalted (*Al-Ali*), The Glorified (*Al-Sabhooh*), The Living and Self-Subsisting (*Al-Hayy al-Qayyum*), The Omnipresent (*Al-Qadir*), The Eternal (*As-Samad*), The Unique (*Al-Wahid*), The First (*Al-Ahad*), The Last (*Al-Akhir*) and others⁶¹. Unlike Allah's Might, Mercy, Power and Generosity, these attributes are exclusively His, and no other creation can partake in these aspects of His Subliminal Divinity. While such attributes foster respect and awe within believers, they also delineate the infinite distance between Allah and His creation. This distance cannot be bridged or fully understood by virtue of humankind's createdness. Unlike Allah's other attributes, such as The Forgiving, The Gentle, and The Generous, which humans can adopt to feel proximity and connection with Him, His Transcendental aspects may lead some believers to feel overwhelmingly isolated and separated from The Divine.

⁶¹ Tables 4 and 5(a).

Mercy and Knowledge

In the *Sahifah*, Al-Sajjad resolves this dichotomy between the Creator and His creation, between the Immortal and the mortal, by looking at His Transcendental Qualities in light of His Attribute of The Knower (*Al-Alim*). In 7:156, the Quran says Allah's "Knowledge encompasses all things". Hence, by His Perfect and Complete Knowledge, Allah bestows the ability to know Him and His nature, cosmos and creations. The *Sahifah* underscores Allah's Knowledge as the Ultimate Knowledge in the beginning verses of supplication 14, 31, 33 and 52⁶² and includes 10 Quranic references and allusions to Allah's Knowledge⁶³. Moreover, there are over 39 mentions of 'knowledge' in the *Sahifah*, of which 11 refer exclusively to Allah's Knowledge. In contrast, the others refer to the *believers' marifah* (acquired knowledge) (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 297). Showing that while humans may not be able to know Allah as He Knows Himself, they can nourish the ability to know him to the best of their abilities – through strife, sincerity and piety. Humanity's ability to know Allah is outlined in the following esoteric *hadith al-qudsi*:

“Who seeketh Me findeth Me. Who findeth Me knoweth Me. Who knoweth Me loveth Me. Who loveth Me, him I love. Whom I love, him I slay. Whom I slay, him must I requite. Whom I requite, Myself am his requital” (Nasr 2011, 60).

Al-Sajjad echoes the ethos of this *hadith* as Allah provides knowledge of Himself to believers, which decreases distance and increases proximity. In the opening verses of ‘The Whispered Prayer of the Knowers’ he says:

“My God, tongues fall short of attaining praise of Thee proper to Thy majesty, intellects are incapable of grasping the core of Thy beauty, eyes fail before gazing upon the glories of Thy face, and Thou hast assigned to Thy creatures no way to know Thee save incapacity to know Thee” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 253).

⁶² Table 2.

⁶³ Tables 4 and 5(a).

The whispered prayer goes on to describe the effects of *marifah* upon believing hearts, minds and souls, which can be understood as their ‘acquittal’:

“The covering has been lifted from their eyes, the darkness of disquiet has been dispelled from their beliefs and their innermost minds, the contention of doubt has been negated from their hearts and their secret thoughts, [and] their breasts have expanded through the verification of true knowledge” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 254).

Hence, while there are some overwhelmingly awe-inspiring attributes of Allah which instil utter unrelatability and distance between Allah and His creation – Knowledge of Him, through Him and His chosen *walis* helps believers and ‘... their spirits reach [the] certitude’ they are capable of reaching (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 254). This certitude, while recognizing and worshipping Allah's Transcendence, can place believers "in the sitting place of intimacy" wherein "their settling place has been settled through reaching the request and attaining the expectation" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 254).

In the concluding verse of this whispered prayer, Al-Sajjad outlines the only way to *marifah* and intimacy: "By Thy mercy and kindness" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 255). Once again, he emphasizes the Quranic notion in 7:156 that Allah's Mercy, Compassion and Kindness are All-Encompassing, so much so that Allah's Mercy encompasses even the unfathomable.

Divine Mercy in the Sahifah

The above sections have focused on Divine Nature generally or in light of Allah's Power and Transcendence in relation to His overwhelming and All-Encompassing Mercy. The current section will solely focus on the quantifiable measure of Allah's overwhelmingly Mercy in the *Sahifah* compared to His Wrath, Vengeance and Punishment by looking at how often these terms are used.

Rahma or Mercy is the single most recurring concept in the *Sahifah*. There is such an overt quantitative and qualitative emphasis on Allah's Mercy that a case could be made that it is more merciful than the Quran itself. The *Sahifah* highlights Allah's Merciful Nature more than any other aspect of Divine Nature and eleven times more than Divine Wrath⁶⁴. While 'His Supplication in seeking Pardon and Mercy' deals exclusively with it, no supplications in the *Sahifah* do not swear by, implore, or invoke Divine Mercy.

There are 19 supplications, which begin with seeking Mercy; 16 of these begin with the Quranic verse (1:1) 'In the Name of Allah, the Most Merciful and Most Compassionate' (*Basmallah ar-Rahman ur-Rahim*), while three supplications begin with other such terms⁶⁵. The *Basmallah* is the most frequent term with which supplications open in the *Sahifah* in correspondence with the Quran; all of whose chapters save *Surah Tawba* begin with this verse. Al-Sadiq says that the *Basmallah* is "the greatest verse in the Book of God" (Nasr 2015, 4). Ali ibn Abi Talib highlights its importance by saying that "the whole of the Quran is contained in the *Fatihah*, and the whole of the *Fatihah* in the *basmallah*, the whole of the *basmallah* in the *ba* [the opening letter]. And the whole of the *ba* in the diacritical point under the *ba*" (Nasr 2015, 3). The significance of the term in the daily lives of Muslims,

⁶⁴ Table 6.

⁶⁵ Table 2.

esotericism and engagement with the Quran can hardly be overstated (Nasr 2015, 33). In the *Sahifah*, even supplications which begin with ‘My Allah’ *Illahi* as the first verse open with it⁶⁶. Such beginnings set the tone for these supplications to be encompassed in Allah’s Mercy, despite varying in thematic concerns such as: ‘The Whispered Prayer of the Complainers’, ‘His Supplication in Distress and Seeking Release’, ‘The Supplication for Saturday’ and ‘The Whispered Prayer of the Hopeful’ among others.

Additionally, 23 supplications end on verses seeking or mentioning Allah as ‘The Most Merciful of the merciful’ – found in the Quranic verses 7:151, 12:64, 21:83 and 23:118. From these 23, 16 supplications include ‘O’ to the term which denotes an imploring tone in the one-on-one dialogue of the supplication, while seven supplications end with using the term ‘thou art’ Merciful as a statement of belief⁶⁷. Quranic verses such as 7:151 and 12:64 entail Prophetic prayers by Moses and Jacob, which are often employed in the *Sahifah* as the section on the mosaic format of the *Sahifah* outlines. It is interesting to note that Prophetic prayers like the supplications of the Twelve Imams and spiritual authorities place an overt emphasis on Allah’s Mercy, which shows the ubiquitous certitude divinely inspired authorities have in it. Moreover, it shows how Allah’s Merciful Nature has captivated humankind across sacred history.

Additionally, 16 Quranic references and allusions about Allah as Merciful are quoted in the *Sahifah*- making it the most frequently quoted concept from the Quran⁶⁸. Through these references, the *Sahifah* complements the Quranic doctrine and imagery of Mercy with Al-Sajjad's elaboration and motifs. For example, like 7:151, verse 7:156, which is

⁶⁶ Table 2.

⁶⁷ Table 3.

⁶⁸ Table 5(a).

quoted in Supplication 58, talks about Allah's Mercy 'encompassing all things'. In 'His Supplication when he Asked Release from his Sins or Pleaded in Seeking Pardon for his Defects', the *Sahifah* quotes from the Quranic verse 40:7 that, “Thou art He who *embraceest everything in mercy and knowledge*” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 56).

The term *Rahma* (Mercy) appears in the *Sahifah* 226 times, making it one of the most often repeated concepts and Names of Allah⁶⁹. In the ‘Whispered Prayer of the Utterly Poor’, Al-Sajjad implores Allah to withhold His Wrath even if believers fall short: “My Allah, have Mercy upon Thy lowly slave of silent tongue and few good works” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 253). Similarly, in the 'The Whispered Prayer of the Fearful', Al-Sajjad says:

“My Allah, look not toward those who profess Thy Unity the doors of Thy mercy ... My Allah, a soul which Thou hast exalted by its professing Thy Unity – how wilt Thou humiliate him by leaving him?” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 237).

Herein, Mercy is seen as part and parcel of Allah’s Presence. Elaborating upon the notion of Mercy as all-Encompassing, Al-Sajjad refers to Allah as One whose “Mercy is wide” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 129) and “... the treasuries of whose Mercy will never be exhausted” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 29).

Throughout the *Sahifah*, Mercy is contextualized as all-encompassing within the one-on-one relationship between believers and Allah and as that which encompasses all relationships in the believer's life. These include their relationship with angels who, as per 40:7, pray for Allah's Mercy on humans and with Muhammad, who is regarded as the "Imam of Mercy” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 21). Praying for Mercy is also extended to “... all the faithful, both men and women” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 40).

⁶⁹ Table 6.

Mercy is also sought as a refugee against evildoers: "Replace his evil action toward me with Thy mercy" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 48). Allah is depicted as one "who has mercy upon him toward whom the servants show no mercy!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 161) and "He through whose Mercy sinners seek aid!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 55). In terms of the one-on-one dialogue between believers and the Divine, Allah is depicted as one who "shows mercy to him who asks Thee for mercy" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 42), indicating that supplicating for Mercy increases the supplicater's "share in Thy [Allah's] favour" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 56).

Mercy is also not just reserved for life in the temporal world but works to "make roomy ... the narrowness of our tombs" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 138) and "protects" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 140) believers on the Day of Judgement. Moreover, Mercy is seen as a spiritual aspiration whose "watering holes" believers yearn to be brought to (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 132) and also a means that "place us in the ranks of those who deserve through Thy mercy the highest elevation" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 136).

Compassion, Kindness and the Good

Additionally, the *Sahifah* is also replete with references to *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*, which complement Allah's Mercy, such as The Compassionate (*Al-Raheem*) and The Kind (*Al-Mannan*).

Al-Sajjad mentions Allah as The Compassionate and His Compassion 25 times in the *Sahifah*⁷⁰. It is included in 16 opening verses as part of the *basmallah*⁷¹, and in 2 closing verses⁷². From the Quran, verse 19:75 is quoted, which vows that "Whosoever is in error,

⁷⁰ Table 6.

⁷¹ Table 2.

⁷² Table 3.

the Compassionate will extend His term” ... “for a chance to make amends. Al-Sajjad speaks of Allah as Compassionate to the creatures” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 36), “compassionate to him who supplicates Thee” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 44), “towards the offenders who turn back” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 111). His Compassion extends to “this world and the next” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 208). Like the *basmallah*, Al-Sajjad often clubs Mercy and Compassion together and implores Allah through them (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 168, 172, 183).

Al-Sajjad also emphasizes Allah as The Kind and His Kindness by mentioning them 82 times throughout the *Sahifah*⁷³ and referencing Quranic verses 57:9 and 59:10⁷⁴. Al-Sajjad implores Allah to “show kindness toward me” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 240) as he “desires Thy [Allah’s] Kindness (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 242) and upon “everyone who supplicates to Thee” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 216). Allah’s Kindness is depicted to have positive effects on believers “... Thy acts of kindness comforts me” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 217). Often Al-Sajjad implores Allah through both His Kindness and Mercy such as in 'His supplication for himself in Confessing Sins after finishing the Night Prayer' "act kindly toward me with the kindly act of mercy" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 115). The consolidation of Allah's Mercy with His Compassion and Kindness reflects the Divine Unity of Allah's Nature, wherein the overarching theme is Mercy, and various merciful qualities are linked together to show how overwhelming they are in Divine Nature.

Al-Sajjad also describes Allah as The Good (*Al-Ihsan* or *Al-Khair*) and the source of all Goodness in 128 different places⁷⁵, though they are not part of the 99 *Asma al-Husna wal-*

⁷³ Table 6.

⁷⁴ Table 5(a).

⁷⁵ Table 6.

Siffat, but stem as an extension of the Quranic understanding of Allah's Mercy. The term *Ihsan* in the Quran is usually for the “beautiful” and “virtuous” “behaviour of believers” (Nasr 2015, 499), but Al-Sajjad extends it towards Allah’s beautiful conduct towards believers through imploring verses such as “givest the good” ((Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 108) and “provide me with its good, the good of all within it, and the good of everything after it!” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 228). In supplication 32, Al-Sajjad thanks Allah for feeding him “through Thy bounty with the food of The Good, the Gentle” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 112) and in 'The Whispered prayer of the Hopeful says, "How should I have hope in other than Thee, when the good – all of it – is in Thy hand?" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 239).

Generosity and Bounty

Another set of *Asma al-Husna wal Siffat* concerning Allah’s Merciful qualities of Magnanimity upon His creation are also prevalent in the *Sahifah*, such as The Generous (*Al-Karim*) and The Giver (*Al-Wahhab*). Al-Sajjad also refers to Him as The Munificent (*Al-Jawad*) alongside His Bounty (*Fazl*) and His Benefaction (*Sana*).

Seven supplications open with verses outlining Allah’s Generosity⁷⁶. Allah as The Generous and His Generosity are mentioned in 81 different verses throughout the text⁷⁷. Many times, Generosity is mentioned alongside other attributes, including Transcendental ones: "Thou art Boundless, Generous" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 50) and other magnanimous attributes: “The Generous, the Giver” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 55). In 'His Supplication when something made him Sorrowful, and offences made him worry’, Al-Sajjad describes Allah’s Face as Generous: “Thy generous face” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988,

⁷⁶ Table 2.

⁷⁷ Table 6.

76). Just as Allah is often described as the Most Merciful of the merciful, He is also described as “the Most Generous of the most generous” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 259), “the most generous in issue!” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 114) and “the most generous of those from whom are asked!” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 116). Al-Sajjad even asks: "Who is more generous, my Allah, than Thou?" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 126).

The Divine Attribute of The Giver is mentioned 92 times in the text. Additionally, Allah is described as the Giver of gifts in 28 different places⁷⁸. Al-Sajjad refers to Allah as “the Giver of abounding favours” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 123) and “the giver of creature’s access to knowledge of Thee” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 215). Allah’s “giving” is described as that which “will not be diminished by the withholding of the withholders” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 31). The *Sahifah* identifies Allah as the giver: “of joy” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 54), “courage” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 92), “relief” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 203) and “mercy” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 201) amongst others. Interestingly, whenever the *Sahifah* mentions Allah's Bestowal and Giving, it is not in terms of punishment, wrath or vengeance, but rather only as the giver of positivity.

Apart from Allah’s Giving and Generous Attributes as per the Quran, Al-Sajjad also refers to Allah as The Munificent (*Al-Jawad*) and his Munificence 25 times in the *Sahifah*⁷⁹. In the ^{third} supplication, Chittick translates The Munificent as ‘*Al-Jawad*’. In contrast, in the 15th supplication, he refers to Allah as "Possessor of majesty and munificence" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 55), wherein 'munificence' is translated as '*Ikram*' in light of Allah’s Name ‘*Zuljalal wal-Ikram*’. However, the Munificent is predominantly translated in light of Allah’s Generosity and Giving as *Al-Jawad*. Allah is referred to as “The Munificent – how

⁷⁸ Table 6.

⁷⁹ Table 6.

plenty Thou art” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 167) and His Munificence is depicted as “free to the askers” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 161). Allah's Munificence is often invoked alongside other magnanimous Merciful attributes, such as in the 25th supplication: “... those given lawful provision in plenty from Thy boundless bounty through Thy munificence and generosity” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 92).

Allah’s ‘bounty’ (*fazl*) is also a recurrent motif in the *Sahifah* and is mentioned in the text at 92 different places⁸⁰. Allah's bounty, like His Mercy, is always depicted as overwhelming; in the first supplication, Al-Sajjad refers to it as "immense" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 19), and Allah as “Lord of the worlds! Thou art of bounty abounding” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 53). Allah’s Mercy is also referred to as bountiful: “I cannot win Thy inclination, arrive at Thy good pleasure, or attain what is with Thee except through obeying Thee and through the bounty of Thy Mercy” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 77).

Similar to Allah’s Munificence and Bounty, the *Sahifah* also refers to Allah as the Benefactor and His Benefaction 57 times⁸¹. Al-Sajjad employs a plethora of descriptions of Allah's benefaction, imploring Allah to; "let me taste the sweetness of benefaction in what I ask" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 37) and “heal me through Thy benefaction” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 73). In other places, benefaction is depicted as that which ‘releases ... from the ties of Thy justice’ (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 130), placing it within the infinite bounds of Allah’s overwhelming Mercy.

Clemency and Forbearance

Another aspect of Allah's Mercy is in response to positive and negative human conditions, especially concerning the flawed, sinning state. Herein, Al-Sajjad identifies Allah as The

⁸⁰ Table 92

⁸¹ Table 6.

Gentle (*Al-Lateef*), 'The Clement (*Al-Rauf*), The Forbearing and Relenting (*At-Tawwab*), The Forgiver (*Al-Ghafoor*), The Pardoner (*Al-Ghaffar*) and The Patient (*As-Saboor*). All these names are included in the 99 *Asma al-Husna wal Siffat*.

The last verse of 'The Supplication for Wednesday' says, "Thou art Gentle to whom Thou wilt" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 228), and there are 21 references to Allah as The Gentle and His gentleness. Allah's gentleness is often juxtaposed with His Power; "intractable affairs yield to Thy power, means are made ready by Thy gentleness" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 37). Al-Sajjad depicts believers as those who "crave Thy gentleness, through which the affairs of sinners are set right" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 59). It is also often woven with other Merciful Attributes: "... through Thy gentleness in the house of Thy generosity and the place of Thy forgiveness and mercy" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 89).

Similarly, Allah is referred to as 'The Clement' at 29 places in the *Sahifah*⁸². He is also described as "Clement to the servants" by quoting verse 2:207 in the Quran⁸³. His Clemency is often spoken of alongside His Mercy, such as in supplication 25, which says, "Thou art ... The Clement, The Merciful" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 93). He is also described as "... the most clement of those from whom mercy is asked" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 115), and His favour is "an act of kindness through [His] tenderness, O Clement" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 155).

Allah is also called 'The Relenting and The Forbearing' (*At-Tawwab*) – one who turns believers away from their sins and into Allah's Forgiveness and Mercy. Quranic verses 2:128 and 9:104 are quoted in reference to Allah's Forbearance, which describes Him as "The Relenting, the Merciful" and One that "accepts repentance from His servants".

⁸² Table 6.

⁸³ Table 5(a).

Allah's Forbearance is mentioned 13 times in the *Sahifah*⁸⁴. In 'His Supplication for Seeking Asylum with Allah', Al-Sajjad implores Allah to "...grant us sanctuary from Thy chastisement through Thy forbearance, for none of us has the endurance for Thy justice" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 61) while in 'The Whispered Prayer of the Repenters' he pleads "strip me not of Thy beautiful forbearance and covering" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 233). Through these verses, Al-Sajjad recognises justice and forbearance as Allah's responses to human actions but implores Him for a merciful response.

Similarly, Allah is depicted as The Patient at six different places in the text⁸⁵. Allah is described as "the Possessor of patient waiting who does not hurry" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 197). His Patience is depicted as an extension of His Mercy:

"My Allah, since Thou hast shielded me with Thy covering and not exposed me, waited patiently for me through Thy generosity, and not hurried me to punishment, and shown me clemency through Thy bounty, and not changed Thy favour upon me or muddled Thy kindly acts toward me, have mercy on my intense misery" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 60).

Forgiveness and Pardon

Allah's most predominant and recurring Attributes in response to human flaws and sins in the *Sahifah* are The Forgiver (*Al-Ghafoor*) and The Pardoner (*Al-Ghaffar*). Both are mentioned in 85 different places, each⁸⁶. Together, they represent Allah's Infinite ability to forgive sins quantifiably and qualitatively.

⁸⁴ Table 6.

⁸⁵ Table 6,

⁸⁶ Table 6.

The 38th supplication begins with the verse, “O Allah, I ask pardon from Thee” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 127)⁸⁷ Furthermore, it ends with the verse "O lover of those who repent", which alludes to the Quranic verse 2:222 (Truly Allah loves those who repent). While 'His Supplication for Monday' ends with the verse, "O He who is Allah and no one other than whom grants forgiveness for sins!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 225)⁸⁸. Through the beginning and ending verses of these supplications, we see that Allah is not only eager to forgive but that both the Quran and the *Sahifah* depict an Allah who fosters love for those who seek pardon. Such conceptions of Allah show Him not only as Merciful but also Affectionate and Loving towards flawed believers who seek to better themselves.

There are ten Quranic verses regarding Allah’s forgiveness and pardon in the *Sahifah*⁸⁹. Interestingly, all the Quranic references that speak about forgiveness also mention mercy. For example, verses 12:53, 25:70, 4:110 and 39:53 all end by calling Allah: "Forgiving and Merciful"⁹⁰. Moreover, they reassure believers about repentance for those who do evil, while 39:53 goes as far as to say, "... Despair not of God's Mercy. Truly God forgives all sins". This verse represents the overwhelming Mercy in the Quran and the intricate proximity between Allah’s Mercy and Forgiveness. Al-Sajjad also highlights this correspondence through the *Sahifah* by saying: “O Most Merciful of those toward whom seekers of mercy keep on turning! O Tenderest of those around whom run seekers of forgiveness!” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 46) and “... I have more trust in Thy forgiveness and Thy mercy than in my own works. Thy forgiveness and Thy mercy are vaster than my sins” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 188).

⁸⁷ Table 2.

⁸⁸ Table 3.

⁸⁹ Table 5(a).

⁹⁰ Table 4.

Al-Sajjad also outlines pardon as a response to human actions: “Meet me with Thy forgiveness just as I have met Thee with my confession” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 106) and “My ugly acts which Thou hast come to know – forgive them! (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 241). Allah’s Forgiveness is not just seen as a Mercy, but also as a medicine for the soul, Al-Sajjad says “nothing wilt ... heal my wound but Thy forgiveness” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 252). In other places he refers to “the sweetness of Thy [Allah’s] pardon and the pleasure of Thy [Allah’s] forgiveness” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 259). Hence, we see that Al-Sajjad defines sins and flaws as access points for Divine Mercy to enter and transform the human soul.

Love and Beauty

Other aspects of Allah's feminine Attributes representing His Mercy, such as Allah's Beauty (*Jamal*), Friendship (*Walayah*) and Love (*Hub*), also appear in the *Sahifah*. The inclusion of these esoteric, feminine aspects, in particular, represents the mystical relationship which outlines the *Sahifah* as the Quran’s sister.

Allah’s Beauty as per His Name of beauty (*Jamal*) is mentioned 15 times in the *Sahifah*⁹¹. Al-Sajjad yearns for “the presence of Thy [Allah’s] beauty” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 242) and for Allah to "confer the beauty of Thy gaze upon my complaint" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 37). Allah’s Beauty is also spoken of alongside His Mercy, “My Allah look not toward those who profess Thy Unity, the doors of Thy mercy and veil not those who yearn for Thee from looking upon the vision of Thy beauty!” (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 237).

One of the Divine Names is *Al-Wali*, which occurs in the *Sahifah* 15 times⁹² Al-Sajjad refers to Allah as "a Friend, Praiseworthy" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 20). He also describes

⁹¹ Table 6.

⁹² Table 6.

friendship with Allah as a protection against worldly friendships: "He whom Thou befriendest will not be injured by the abandonment of the abandoners" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 31). He prays for Allah to "make us worthy of the generosity Thou hast promised Thy friends" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 145).

The *Sahifah* also refers to Allah's Love and Allah as The Loving (*Al-Wadood*) and the Beloved at least 62 times⁹³. Interestingly, while the Quranic image focuses on a loving Allah, the *Sahifah*, along with focusing on a Loving Allah, also focuses on believers in love with Allah. In 'The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers', it says: "I ask from Thee love for Thee, love for those who love Thee, love for every work which will join me to Thy nearness and that Thou makest Thyself more beloved to me than anything other than Thee" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 249). Al-Sajjad also prays for "the most plentiful portion of Thy [Allah's] love" and "to drink at the pools of Thy [Allah's] love" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 245). Love for Allah and by Allah are depicted as the most extraordinary mystical gifts in the *Sahifah* and represent the highest forms of Mercy for the believers.

Mercy vs. Wrath

This contrasts with the Divine Mercy mentioned in the *Sahifah*, which is not limited to the discussion above. There is minimal mention of Allah's Wrath (*Ghazab*), Vengeance (*Intikam*), Chastisement (*Azaab*), Punishment (*Aiqab*) and Loathing. Moreover, one of the most salient features of the text is that Al-Sajjad never mentions any of the above without drawing a parallel to Allah's Merciful qualities. The *Sahifah* only references Wrath in 19 different places, in comparison to 226 mentions of Mercy alone⁹⁴.

⁹³ Table 6.

⁹⁴ Table 6.

None of the supplications begins or ends with the mention of Allah's Wrath. There are 9 Quranic verses referenced throughout the text which speak of Allah's Wrath⁹⁵ These verses warn the disobedient. In 14:7, Allah proclaims, "If you give thanks, I shall surely grant you increase, but if you are ungrateful, truly My punishment is severe". Similarly, 16:85 says, "Those who did wrong see the punishment; it shall not be lightened for them, nor shall they be granted respite". These verses, along with the others quoted in the *Sahifah*, warn believers to avoid ingratitude and seek forgiveness.

Al-Sajjad, however, does not speak of Allah's Wrath without His Mercy, often outlined as His Refuge, which is mentioned in the *Sahifah* at 46 different places, juxtaposed with wrath. For example, in the beginning verses of the ^{eighth} supplication, Al-Sajjad seeks "refuge in Thee ... from the violence of wrath" (sup 8)⁹⁶. Wrath is also juxtaposed against His Mercy; "Thou art He whose mercy runs before His wrath!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 56)" and His Clemency; "nothing repels Thy wrath but Thy clemency" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 191). Wrath is also contrasted with Allah's Love and Kindness in 'The Whispered Pray of the Fearful'; "give me sanctuary from Thy painful wrath and Thy mighty anger!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 238).

Mercy vs. Vengeance

In contrast to Allah's Generous and Compassionate responses to human sins, Allah's vengeance is only mentioned in the *Sahifah* at 25 different places⁹⁷. Just like wrath, vengeance is also only mentioned alongside Allah's Merciful Attributes, and only verse 3:4 from the Quran is quoted in reference to it⁹⁸. In the ^{first} supplication, Al-Sajjad praises

⁹⁵ Table 5(a).

⁹⁶ Table 2.

⁹⁷ Table 6.

⁹⁸ Table 5(a).

Allah as one who did not "hasten us onto His vengeance. No, He went slowly with us through mercy, in generosity and awaited our return through His clemency, in mildness" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 19). Similarly, Allah's delay in a vengeful response to human sins is outlined in the 37th supplication: "Thou dost not hurry him to Thy vengeance, so that he may seek to replace his state in disobeying Thee, with the state of turning back to obey Thee" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 126).

Allah is also regarded as the "protector against His [own] vengeance" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 20) since Al-Sajjad regards humankind as incapable of protection against Allah: "... for my strength cannot bear Thy vengeance" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 129). Al-Sajjad also regards Allah as "He whose pardon is greater than His vengeance" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 46), just as His Mercy is greater than His Wrath.

Similarly, Allah's punishment is scarcely mentioned in the *Sahifah*, occurring only 17 times⁹⁹, with only 3 Quranic references¹⁰⁰. Only the ^{ninth} supplication ends with a verse describing Allah's punishment. Even then, Al-Sajjad is imploring Allah to make his "heart" and "eyes" subservient "to that which makes incumbent Thy reward lest ... and evil deed remain with us, by which we might merit Thy punishment!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 41). Similar to Allah's vengeance, Allah's "pardon is higher than His punishment" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 56) and "He does not overdo the punishment of him who disobeys" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 56) if they supplicate and repent. In contrast to Allah's boundless Bounty and Giving of gifts – His disgrace is only mentioned in 6 places in the *Sahifah*¹⁰¹ in relation to His Name, 'The Giver of Dishonour' (*Al-Mudhill*). Nevertheless, these are also in relation

⁹⁹ Table 6.

¹⁰⁰ Table 5(a).

¹⁰¹ Table 6.

to Allah's protection from the disgrace that the human condition deserves; in supplication xx, Al-Sajjad says, "How many faults I have committed, yet Thou didst not ... collar me with their detested disgrace" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 57). Similarly, while the *Sahifah* is replete with Allah's Love, his loathing is only mentioned once¹⁰². Even then Al-Sajjad only prays for Allah to "give refuge from separation from Thee and Thy loathing" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 248) and to "place us with him whom Thou hast chosen for Thy nearness and Thy friendship, purified through Thy affection and Thy Love" (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 248) in 'The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers'.

The above analysis shows how Al-Sajjad elaborates on Allah's overwhelming Mercy through different *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*. Just as the Quran weaves together different attributes of Allah's Mercy, the *Sahifah* also highlights the correspondence in Divine Unity. Similar to the Quran, which juxtaposes Allah's wrath with His Mercy to demonstrate the restricted nature of Allah's Wrath and the All-Encompassing nature of His Mercy. This section has focused on the theme of Allah's Nature in the *Sahifah* in correspondence to Divine Nature in the Quran; it has only presented a brief overview, and an in-depth analysis of this concept is necessary for academia concerning Shi'a mysticism.

Analysis of selected verses

Although there is no supplication in the *Sahifah* that does not implore Allah for His Mercy, Al-Sajjad's 'supplication in seeking pardon and mercy' is exclusively reserved for this endeavour. It is one of the most raw and moving supplications in the prayer manual. The supplication is an unmatched vantage point on the unique individuality of Al-Sajjad and his relationship with Allah - capturing the spirit of his devotion to worship. Moreover, it

¹⁰² Table 6.

serves as an exemplar par excellence of the fourth Imam's theological and philosophical framework on Divine Nature, the human fitrah and the relationship between them. The supplication is overflowing with confessions of human inadequacies juxtaposed with unyielding faith in Allah's Mercy. It encapsulates the flux of the fragmented human soul, which frantically moves between its transgressions against Allah and others, and the transgressions of others against itself. These fragments are then confronted with vivid, loving and intimate descriptions of Allah's Mercy, which leaves the readers unable to wallow in despair and elevates them to a hopeful submission (taslimah) to Allah's Merciful Decree.

The supplication primarily addresses two human states – both seemingly overwhelming. One is overwhelmed with palatable anxiety and dread over its own shortcomings, pain caused by others, and the fear of harming others. The second state is filled with such brazen, impassioned requests, confessions and implorations of Allah's Mercy, that readers are not only overwhelmed by the Reality of Divine Mercy but also by Al-Sajjad's intimacy with and knowledge of the Divine. His intimacy with Allah instils the desire to seek such an intimate relationship in the readers as well. The verses depict a passion-struck lover, who sees no solution to his existential angst except utter submission to Allah. They show a lover who cannot focus on the limited but overwhelming states of human pessimism in the face of his Beloved's Infinitely Merciful Face. The verses of the supplication move in and out of these two states, outlining the correct ethical attitude believers should embody when confronted with despair in various situations, till the supplication reaches its climax. Then the promise of Allah's Mercy and Pardon effortlessly overwhelms the lesser realities of

their despair and shortcomings, and one is only left with the overwhelming experience of being touched by the Ever-Pervasive and Ultimate Compassion of the Divine Reality.

For Shi'a believers, who spend their lives in mourning for the tragedies and sufferings incurred by Al-Sajjad, it is a moment of awe for their Imam. By reciting this supplication, they can behold and experience within themselves, why and how Al-Sajjad is regarded as 'the ornament of worshippers' and referred to, as 'the one with perfected rectitude'. While his external realities increase their sympathies for him, a glimpse into his inward reality only leaves them awe-struck and hopeful. Their hopefulness is inspired and encouraged, by contextualizing their own tragedies against the backdrop of Al-Sajjad's life. Herein, their reverence for and faith in their Imam and wali reveals a sense of spiritual resilience which aspires to incorporate Al-Sajjad's spirit of worship and belief in Allah's Mercy within themselves. Alongside, a desire to emulate Al-Sajjad's kindness, benevolence and compassion for those who have wronged them. It is imperative to remember, that for Shi'a believers their Imams are only third to the Quran and the Prophet. Their faith remains incomplete without the guidance of their divinely inspired walis just as it would remain incomplete without the guidance of their Prophet. Hence, if their beloved Imam is utterly certain of Allah's Mercy, they feel obligated to elevate their faith to such levels of certainty as well. More than anything this supplication offers relief from bitterness, blame, despair and low self-worth by elevating believers to a newfound sense of human dignity, self-worth, love and knowledge which only a sense of utter submission to Allah can bring.

Verses 1-4

The first four verses of the *dua* invite readers to partake in a unique approach to seeking Allah's Pardon and Mercy. They promote the ethical attitude that the best condition to ask

Allah for Mercy and Pardon requires one to be merciful and forgiving towards their fellow creations. The first verse sets the tone for this ethical alignment with Allah and others, by saying, "bar me from harming any believer, male or female, and any Muslim, male and female" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 128). While in the second verse, Al-Sajjad pleads with Allah to, "... inquire not from him about what he committed towards me and expose him not through what he earned by me!" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 128). The structural parallelism in these four verses is profound, it brings readers to a two-fold realization. Firstly, believers can actualize their individual and personal shortcomings alongside the collective shortcomings of humankind. Secondly, while believers are asking Allah for Forgiveness and Mercy, Al-Sajjad is encouraging them to become more merciful and forgiving towards others. Such an approach to sinning and the shortcomings of the fitrah invites readers to experience these Divine Attributes in a wholesome manner, and the supplication covers the duality of their spectrums. Hence, believers not only aspire to be recipients of Divine Mercy and Pardon but conduits of them as well. Herein, Al-Sajjad reveals a profound aspect of the human fitrah; that being merciful and forgiving are some of the only Divine qualities that human beings are also encouraged to partake in and nurture within their own nature.

In light of the atrocities that Al-Sajjad faced at the hands of Muslims who persecuted him and his family, these verses hold unparalleled significance for Shi'a believers. If after everything, their Imam suffered his outlook towards others was not riddled with hatred, bitterness and resentment – then devout Shi'a believers may feel a sense of obligation to forgive those who transgress against them. Apart from increasing their respect for their Imam, these verses also raise the standard for their own moral and ethical conduct towards

other creatures, whether they are non-believers, believers or Muslims. Wherein, the best way for one to seek forgiveness and ask for Mercy, is by being merciful and forgiving themselves.

In addition to helping readers foster a wholesome moral and ethical standard, this supplication also opens up a collective perspective on their relationships with Allah. As the section on the thematic concerns states, the prayers in the Sahifah are mostly concerned with the bilateral relationship between each soul and the Divine. The Sahifah's philosophical and theological framework narrows existence down to this one relationship. Once believers settle into this relationship, Al-Sajjad uses it as the lens to view everything else in the world. Which is to say, that every other relationship is a trilateral relationship, between the believer, Allah and another. Wherein the other can be one's parents, one's children, one's enemies, cosmological and natural events and so on. The main aim of this distinction is to create an Allah-centric approach to every aspect of human life. The third verse of the supplication proceeds to state, "... recompense me for my pardoning them with Thy pardon and for my supplicating for them with Thy mercy" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 128-9). Hence when one is mindful of being forgiving and merciful for the sake of Allah, or for the sake of their own souls – they are more likely to be forgiven. Such a moral spiritual attitude not only fosters humility and patience for others but makes one more understanding towards humanity as a collective. Such empathy for humanity is what sets the supplications of the Sahifah apart from other prayer manuals – it is deeply marked by the empathetic personality and character of Al-Sajjad.

Verse five

The fifth verse of this supplication is arguably one of the most authentic, powerful and raw implorations in the Sahifah and Islamic devotional literature as a whole. It communicates the essence of Al-Sajjad's entire theological and philosophical premise on the overwhelming nature of Divine Mercy in the face of human shortcomings, most poetically and poignantly, which touches every corner of the psyche and the soul. The verse begins by saying:

... protect me from what Thy decision mandates and save me from what Thy justice decides, for my strength, cannot bear Thy vengeance and my obedience cannot stand up to Thy displeasure! (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 129)

The Sahifah is replete with implorations and pleadings from Al-Sajjad on not being met with Justice and only asking Allah for His Mercy. This is a profound concept in Islamic spirituality, which serves as a cornerstone of faith and understanding of the Divine Nature as well as the human fitrah. The concept is centred upon two notions; firstly the human fitrah despite all its attempts is incapable of transgressions against the rights of Allah and others. Secondly, the notion that even the most arrogant sinner is not capable of being dealt with Allah's Justice – which is to say, no one can bear against themselves what they commit. Hence, human beings are left helpless and in despair without the hope and belief of Allah's forgiveness. The second half of the verse emphasizes:

If Thou recompensest me with the right, Thou wilt destroy me, if Thou dost not shield me in Thy mercy, Thou wilt lay me waste (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 129)

These two lines capture the essence of Al-Sajjad's love for Allah and his utter dependence on his Lord. They paint the picture of a bemoaning lover making impassioned declarations to his Beloved. The image that comes to mind is one of a garden, helpless to the forces of nature, dependent upon fertility from the ground, rain from the skies and light from the sun – blooming beautifully when the Beloved bestows Love and Tenderness upon it, and being

left wasted, plundered and lifeless without Allah's Sustenance, Bestowal and Light. If these verses are incredibly profound in the image of a lover or a garden fearing destruction and destitution – they are even more profound when read against the backdrop of Al-Sajjad's life. Never does he implore his captives or oppressors in this manner, never do his outward realities bow in the face of injustice nor does his patience and endurance. However, when faced with the prospect of his Beloved turning away from him in displeasure, he displays no patience, no endurance and no restraint – and declares himself incapable, incapacitated and destroyed without Allah.

Verse eight

Similarly, the eighth verse of this supplication introduces a novel concept of Islamic spirituality. While the first four verses create a sense of collective sinning, shortcomings and partaking in forgiving and showing mercy, the eighth verse goes back to the bilateral relationship with Allah. It pays homage to the Quranic verse which says "...no soul does evil, save against itself, and none shall bear the burden of another..." (6:164). The concept is also present in verses 17:15, 35:18, 39:7 and 53:38, which emphasizes the concept that no other creature can carry the burden of another's sins. However, Al-Sajjad turns this concept into an extension of the *shahadah*, which is to say, no being except for Allah's Being:

I ask Thee to carry those of my sins whose carrying weighs me down and I seek
help from Thee in that whose heaviness oppresses me (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 130).

Such brazenness or audacity from anyone else could be considered blasphemy against Allah's Justice – only when the Imam vested with divine knowledge, wisdom and guidance makes such implorations and claims to Allah's Mercy, is it possible for sinning repenters to believe in such an aspect of Divine Nature. In the tenth verse of this supplication, Al-

Sajjad repeats this notion for emphasis by aspiring to be, "freed by Thy pardon from the bonds of Thy displeasure and released by Thy benefaction from the ties of Thy justice" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 130). Al-Sajjad instills within his readers, his divinely bestowed tawakul and the language, tone and attitude to make such requests from Allah, which helps them comprehend and hold fast to Allah's superseding and overwhelming Mercy. He fosters a sense of unabashed intimacy which does not tread outside the bounds of taqwa but rather shows what all can be asked for and acquired when one fears none but Allah. Herein, Al-Sajjad is not belittling sins but rather focusing on the Infinite Capacity of the Divine and encourages readers to elevate themselves spiritually by repenting and asking Allah for such favours. Emphasizing the fact that no ask from Allah is too big or too brazen when one is intimately connected with Him.

Verse Nine

Another verse which may shock readers and question dry, rigid jurisprudential understanding of Divine Mercy and Justice, quickly succeeds the eighth verse. The ninth verse builds upon the idea that 'no one but Allah...' can accomplish the impossible and that when believers humble themselves in submission to Allah, He Can and Will release them from His rights upon them. This is to say, that worship, whether it is in the form of taslimah, tawbah, taqwa or tawakkul can not only alter believer's destiny but also releases them from the clutches of their fate:

... Give to my soul in spite of its wrongdoing, and appoint Thy mercy to carry my
burden! How many evildoers Thy mercy had overtaken! How many wrongdoers
Thy mercy has embraced! (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 130).

Herein, giving to the soul and appointing Allah's mercy refers to the covenant that all souls made with Allah, before coming into the world to fulfil their pledge as devout and righteous

servants who would avoid incurring Allah's displeasure. If the eighth verse leaves believers in awe of the ask Al-Sajjad makes of Allah, this verse of the Sahifah is widely regarded in its commentaries as even more impactful, as it asks Allah to release the believing soul from its primordial pledge and covenant with Allah. Though the Quran is clear that "every soul shall be a pledge for what it has earned" (74:38) and Al-Sajjad does not seek release through obedience and righteous deeds alone, for he understands that human beings will falter in fulfilling this oath. Hence, he encourages believers to seek release from it through devotion in repentance alongside attempting to fulfil the covenant. These verses are above all, proof texts of Allah's Mercy, meant to encourage and reassure believers of Allah's Immensely Compassionate and Clement Nature.

If the believer came to this supplication out of the low self-worth that the realization of sins often brings in devout believers, it leaves them with aspirations of an elevated self. When believers are certain of Allah's Mercy with unwavering faith like Al-Sajjad, then they are less likely to be affected by any outward or inner reality except the Divine Reality. Instead of approaching sinning and their human shortcomings with guilt, remorse, and regret they find relief, kindness and understanding from both the Imam and the Divine. If they perceive the actions of others with heavy bitterness, resentment and blame they are now left with a sense of lightness and, a greater understanding of the collective human *fitrah* which squarely aligns with their tasks in the world – to seek Allah's pleasure and avoid His displeasure.

The Sahifah on the Quran

There are over 316 references and allusions to Quranic verses in the *Sahifah*; interestingly, 27 are verses about the Quran itself and the various ways it is a means to, source of and proof of Allah's Mercy. The following Quranic verses about the Quran are quoted or alluded to in the *Sahifah*: 25:1, 31:20, 34:3, 35:29, 39:23, 2:185, 18:49, 5:48, 13:31, 18:49, 2:129, 2:143, 2:285, 3:4, 4:174, 6:115, 10:57, 10:61, 12:2, 14:1, 17:82, 18:109, 20:113, 41:3, 57:25, 59:21 and 76:23¹⁰³. Similarly, there are over forty mentions of the Quran, including outlining its qualities, characteristics and functions in Quranic terminology and Al-Sajjad's descriptions through the *Sahifah*. This section seeks to analyse the spiritual context of how the Quran has been mentioned in the *Sahifah* and how it represents the Overwhelming Mercy of Allah's Nature.

The Quran is spoken of in various ways, including talking about Muhammad, Gabriel, and the Twelve in association with the revelation. There are also detailed descriptions of the Quran's roles in a believer's life, death, afterlife, and the day of judgement, which means that the Quran is a multi-dimensional companion for the human soul throughout its journey. Al-Sajjad also invokes the mention of the Quran, which is something by whose sake believers can ask Allah for His Mercy, Bounty, and Forgiveness. Another salient feature of Quranic mentions in the *Sahifah* is to hold Allah to His promise of mercy, guidance and forgiveness by using verses of the Quran and mentions of His Most Beautiful Names and Attributions as proof of Allah's promises. Overall, Al-Sajjad invokes descriptions, qualities, functions, characteristics and specific verses of the Quran to depict Allah's overwhelming Mercy in the *Sahifah*.

¹⁰³ Table 5(c).

Prophets, angels, Imams and revelation

In the supplication titled 'Blessing upon Muhammad and his household', Al-Sajjad invokes blessings upon Muhammad for his Prophetic function of being "entrusted" by Allah with His "revelation", which "distinguishes" Muhammad from other creatures. He is described as "the Imam of mercy, leader of good and the key to blessings" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 21). Similarly, in the 3rd verse 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran', the Holy Prophet is referred to as one upon whom Allah's "revelation was sent down" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 133), which is an allusion to the Quranic verse 76:23, describing Muhammad as the recipient of the Quran. In the fifth and sixth verses of the same supplication, Al-Sajjad depicts Muhammad as one "inspired with the science of its [the Quran] wonders" and "its preacher" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134).

In the supplication 'Calling down Blessings upon the Bearers of the Throne', Al-Sajjad invokes Allah's blessings upon Gabriel due to his station of being "entrusted with Thy revelation" in the fourth verse (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 23), and similarly in the tenth verse (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 24). Both these references to praise for Gabriel's role in bringing down Allah's revelation are allusions to verse 81:20 of the Quran.

The Twelve Imam's role and the *walayah* function in relation to revelation are mentioned in the 'Supplication on the day of *Arafa*' as those who "establish Thy book, Thy bounds, Thy laws and the norms of Thy Messenger's *Sunnah*" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 172). In the 'Supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran' alongside mention of Muhammad's role as its messenger, Al-Sajjad describes the Twelve Imams as "the heirs of its knowledge, as interpreters" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) in the fifth verse. Similarly, in the sixth verse of

the same supplication, the Twelve are depicted as the Quran's "guardians" who "confess" and "attest" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) to Allah's Authorship of the Quran.

There is a clear relationship between angels, messengers, and the Twelve and the Quranic revelation in the *Sahifah*. However, what distinguishes the *walayah* function from the Prophetic or angelic functions in association with revelation is a prayer for the *Imams* by Al-Sajjad to prevent "doubts" from "assailing us" and "deviation from its straightforward path shaking us" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134). At the same time, only blessings are sent upon Muhammad and Gabriel for their service. Such instances are what Constance aptly described as Al-Sajjad's "deep humility" (Constance, xvi), which is replete in the *Sahifah* whether referring to his station as a *wali* or as one afflicted by the human condition.

Describing the Quran

The vast majority of mentions of the Quran in the *Sahifah*—whether from Quranic verses or Al-Sajjad's own words—describe the Quran's qualities, characteristics and function and their relevance for the believer's journey through life, the afterlife and *qiyammah*. These show how the Quran is a source of mercy, providing proof-texts of Allah's Mercy.

The standard and the guardian

The Quran refers to itself as the Criterion or the Standard (*Furqan*) in 2:185, 3:4 and 25:1. Al-Sajjad expands upon this notion by calling the Quran the standard through which Allah "hast separated Thy lawful from Thy unlawful" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 133). The Quranic function of being a criterion is further expanded upon by Al-Sajjad, who calls it "a witness [with Allah] by its declaring the lawful the lawful and its declaring the unlawful unlawful" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 137). Highlighting the Quranic function of laying down *Shariah* is

imperative in the *Sahifah*, as it shows that the innermost mystical realities of worship can only be achieved within the framework of Divine Law.

The *Sahifah* also refers to the supremacy of the Quran over other Divinely Revealed books by alluding to verses 5:48 and 39:23 – “... a guardian over every book Thou hast sent down, preferring it over every narrative which Thou hast recounted” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 133). Al-Sajjad emphasises the Quran's role as a guardian, not only over other books but "a guardian over the instigations of Satan and confusing thoughts" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 136), a “protector” against “transgressing against [Allah’s] bounds” and through which Allah “preserves” believers from “the pits of unbelief and the motives for hypocrisy” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 137) in life.

Al-Sajjad further expands upon the Quran's ability to preserve by referring to "its preservation's handhold", which protects believers from being "touched by the hands of disaster" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134). The Quran’s role as a “leader” at “resurrection” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 137) is also referenced. By highlighting these Quranic functions, Al-Sajjad is also referencing Allah's Attributes of being A Guardian (*Al-Hafiz*) and Protector (*Al-Waris*)¹⁰⁴ – showing how Allah manifests Himself through the text of the Quran.

The beautiful guiding light

In the third verse of ‘His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran’, the *Sahifah* alludes to Quranic verse 4:174, which calls the Quran "a light" (*Nur*). The attribution of the Quran as a ‘light’ is in relation to Allah’s quality of being “The Light of the heavens and the earth” in Surah An-Nur, verse 35. The *Sahifah* refers to the Quran as "a light" that "guides" believers from "the shadows of error and ignorance" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 133),

¹⁰⁴ Table 5(a).

which is an allusion to the Quranic verses (14:1, 57:9 and 65:11). In the *Sahifah*, Al-Sajjad further expands upon the notion of the Quran as a light, by referring to "... the brightness of its morning"; "the shining of its discourse"; the "light from its lamp" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135); and that which "illuminates the darkness of our graves" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 138). The Quran is also referred to as "an intimate in the shadows of the night" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135) in reference to Allah's attribution as The Friend (*Al-Wali*)¹⁰⁵.

Another Quranic function, relating to Allah's *Asma al-Husna* alongside *Al-Nur* and *Al-Wali*, is the reference to the Quran as guidance (*Hidayah*) – as stated in 2:185 – (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 142) as Allah is The Guide (*Al-Hadi*)¹⁰⁶. The *Sahifah* refers to the Quran as "the guidepost of deliverance" (*alam-e-nijat*), which ensures that "he who repairs straightway to its prescription will not astray" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) in life. On "the plains of resurrection", the *Sahifah* identifies the Quran as "a cause ... of deliverance" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135).

In the same light, the Quran is called the "Book" by whose "recitation" Allah "expands the breasts" of the reciters and "lessens the burden of sin" in 'His supplication for Saturday' (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 232). The Quran's ability to deliver one from their sins is emphasized again in 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran' when Al-Sajjad prays to Allah to "lessen for us through the Quran the weight of heavy sins" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134). Al-Sajjad also underscores the importance of reciting the Quran by asking Allah to "... attachest to our hearts an understanding of the Quran's wonders and its restraining similitude" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 136).

¹⁰⁵ Table 5(a).

¹⁰⁶ Table 5(a).

Moreover, Al-Sajjad prays for "the beauty of its [the Quran's] expression" to "smooth the roughness of our tongues" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134). The beauty of the Quran is in relation to Allah as The Most Beautiful (*Al-Jamal*)¹⁰⁷ Through its recitation, believers are able to access both Allah's and the Quran's beauty. The impact of the Quran upon various human modalities, such as tongues, sight, hearts, and others, is related to its Divine Quality of being Allah's discourse, which lifts humanity out of despair and into the light, in life, death, and *Qiyammah*.

A healing and a balance

Another quality and Quranic function that the *Sahifah* highlights is the Quran as healing (*Al-Shifa*), as per 10:57 and 17:82. Al-Sajjad calls it "A healing for him who turns his ear towards hearing it, with the understanding of attestation" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134). In 'His supplication in imploring God' attesting to the Quran as "Thy Book" alongside "Thy messengers" and renouncing "every object of worship other than Thee" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 205) is also mentioned as an article of Islamic faith.

Another Quranic attribute mentioned in the *Sahifah* is the Quran as a "Just Balance" (*Al-Mizan*). Al-Sajjad refers to the Quran as "a just balance whose tongue does not incline away from the truth" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134). This Quranic quality and function is in light of Allah being The Just (*Al-Adl*) and The Truth (*Al-Haq*)¹⁰⁸, which is to say that the Quran, as the word of Allah, does not stray from establishing truth and justice in the hearts of believers.

¹⁰⁷ Table 5(a).

¹⁰⁸ Table 5(a).

A firm text

The *Sahifah* also comments on the language, form and structures of the Quran – which is depicted as both ambiguous and unambiguous. The Quran identifies itself as a “distinguished ... Arabic Quran” in 41:3 and similarly in 12:2 and 20:113. The *Sahifah* alludes to these Quranic verses by referring to the Quran as: "... A book which Thou hast distinguished very distinctly for Thy servants" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 133) and "... through which thou hast made plain the approaches to Thy ordinances" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 133). Al-Sajjad also refers to “its ambiguous parts” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) and “its ambiguities” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135). However, their mention is always alongside seeking “refugee” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) or “haven” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135) with its “clear signs” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) and within “its fortified stronghold” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135). Al-Sajjad further prays for Allah to "make us one who holds fast to its cord" and find "rest in the shadow of its wing" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135).

Such descriptions of the Quran can be seen in relation to the divinely bestowed authority to interpret the Quran, which lies with the Twelve *Imams* in the Shi'ite tradition, as a previous section of this paper highlights. Indeed, holding fast to the cord of the Quran is the source of the Twelve's infallibility, as per Al-Sajjad. It can also be viewed in light of the believer seeking the protection of Quranic certainty from Quranic vagueness – as the Quran and the *Sahifah* emphasis the “firm text of His Book” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 17) and the “firm text of its verses” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 134) far more than its ambiguities.

The Quran as a companion

Apart from expanding upon Quranic descriptions of its qualities, characteristics, and functions, Al-Sajjad introduces a wide array of Quranic functions related to the human condition and its modalities. These modalities and their functions include the heart as the seat of the soul, eyes as observers of realities, limbs through which one spiritually and physically strives and others (Ali ibn al-Husayn 1988, 297-300).

The first set of descriptions elaborates on how the Quran serves as a means of reaching heaven. In the eighth verse of 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran', the *Sahifah* emphasises the various ways – in life, death and the day of judgement – that the Quran facilitates a believing soul's journey to heaven. It is also referred to as "our meditation to the noblest stations of Thy honour", "a ladder by which we may climb to the place of safety", and "a means whereby we may reach the bliss of the house of remembrance" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 135). Similarly, in the twelfth verse of the same supplication, Al Sajjad implores Allah to "make firm the slips of our feet during the shaking of the bridge across hell on the day of the passage over it" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 138).

A second set of descriptions found in the *Sahifah* is in relation to the Quran establishing the unlawful, and Al-Sajjad elaborates on the ways the Quran serves as a deterrence for various human modalities from the unlawful and sinning. The tenth verse of 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran' calls the Quran "an obstruction" for "our feet" from "acts of disobedience" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 136). "A silencer" for "tongues" which "prevents" them from "plunging into falsehood", "a restrainer" for "limbs ...

committing sins", and "an unroller" for those "rolled up in heedlessness" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 136).

Other descriptions outline how the Quran proliferates righteousness and aids the believers in reaching Allah in life, death and on the day of deliverance. Herein, Al-Sajjad emphasises the wide variety of Quranic functions which benefit believers. In the third set of descriptions found in the eleventh verse of 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran' the Quran is identified as a force of Divine Nature on the day of judgement: "permanence... [to]... the rightness of our outward selves"; that which "washes away the dirt" of "hearts and ties of heavy sins"; a "gatherer" for "scattered affair"; a "quencher" for "the thirst of burning heat" on *Qiyammah*; and a cover which "clothes in the robes of security on the Day of the Greatest Terror at our uprising" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 136).

The reference to the Quran as one that covers is an allusion to Allah's Attribution of *Al-Ghaffar* (The Pardoner) and *Al-Ghafoor* (The Forgiver)¹⁰⁹, which gives cover to human sins. The twelfth verse of the same supplication outlines the fourth set of descriptions, which refer to Quranic facilitation during a believer's life as a "redresser" which "redresses lack and destitution in poverty"; a "driver" towards "the comforts of life and an abundance of plentiful provisions"; a "turner" which "turns aside blameworthy character traits and base moral qualities" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 137) in light of Allah's Name *At-Tawwab* (One Who Turns)¹¹⁰.

¹⁰⁹ Table 5(a).

¹¹⁰ Table 5(a).

The fifth set of descriptions is found in the thirteenth verse of 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran' which describes the ways the Quran facilitates a believer's soul at the moment that death comes to claim them as described in the Quranic verses (8:6 and 75:26-27), which the *Sahifah* references directly. Al-Sajjad implores Allah through the Quran to "make easy for our souls at death": the distress of the driving"; "the effort of moaning", and "the succession of the rattling" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 138). Hence, it is clear that Al-Sajjad is not only inspired by the overwhelmingly Mercy within the Quran, but the *Sahifah* views the Quran as a source of mercy.

The Quran as a Mercy

These descriptions of the Quran outline its functions, qualities and characteristics, which emphasise its role as proof and a means for accessing Allah's Mercy. Furthermore, there is a unique focus on Allah's overwhelming Mercy through the Quran in the *Sahifah*. The Quran is discussed by terms such as "Thy Book", "Thy revelation", and "Thy verses", etc., to implore Allah for His Mercy. In this light, the Quran is described in two ways: i) to ask Allah for Mercy for the sake of the Quran and ii) quoting verses of the Quran, outlining Allah's Mercy in response to various human conditions, as proof texts to hold Allah to His promises of Mercy.

The Quran clarifies that "Verily, Allah does not back out of His promises" (3:9). Holding Allah to His promises in merciful verses of the Quran can be seen as a method of reminding and reassuring believers of Allah's mercy, superseding his wrath. It can further be seen as encouraging believers to stay faithful to their promises of piety and righteousness, as stated in (17:34) – "And be true to every promise, for verily you will be called to account for every promise which you have made". The portions of the *Sahifah* use the Quran as proof

texts to emphasise Allah's Mercy and implore Allah's Mercy for the sake of the Quran, which is imperative in understanding the overwhelming nature of Allah's Mercy in both these texts.

Asking for Allah's Mercy, Compassion and Kindness for the sake of the Quran is evident in the 'Supplication for Thursday'. In this supplication, Al-Sajjad "seeks" the mercy of Allah's "mediation" for the sake of "the inviolability of the Quran" as an expression of 'reliance' upon both Allah and His Book (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 229). Herein, Quranic qualities such as its "inviolability" are not used as mere descriptions of the nature of the Quran, but rather as functions which deliver salvation. In 'His supplication upon completing a reading of the Quran', Al-Sajjad explicitly asks for Mercy for the sake of the Quran rather than through a specific Quranic quality. Verse 15 of the supplication states, "Through the Quran have mercy upon the lowliness of our station" on the day of judgement (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 138).

Once again, the Quran's Mercy is highlighted as one that accompanies a believer through life, death, and *Qiyaamah*. In another instance, such as 'His supplication on the day of *Arafah*', Al-Sajjad implores Allah not to "frighten" him "with a fright by which I will despair or a terror through which I will dread" but rather make him "stand in awe of Thy threat ... and tremble at the recitation of Thy verses" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 183). Such a detailed and specific imploration for the sake of the Quran can be taken as an asking for a merciful god-fearing consciousness (*Taqwa*). The imploration leaves believers with awe, wonder and amazement of Allah's Mercy rather than despair or dread over His wrath. Here, a direct comparison between Allah's Mercy and His Wrath's consequences on humanity is also delineated.

The Merciful Creator

Direct quotations of Quranic verses as proof-texts to hold Allah to his promises of Mercy superseding his wrath in the *Sahifah* are about specific Attributes of Allah, as per His *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*. Moreover, Al-Sajjad underscores how various *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat* align with various aspects of the human condition and how believers should implore Allah for Mercy, keeping this alignment in mind. For example, in 'His supplication for himself in confessing sins after finishing the night prayer' Al-Sajjad alludes to the Quranic verses 23:12-14, which outline Allah as The Creator (*Al-Khaliq*)¹¹¹ Who "described in Thy [His] Book" the process of creating humanity from "a drop, then a clot, then a tissue, then bones" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 115). Al-Sajjad regards Allah's Merciful act of Creating as "Thy beginning with immense favours", for which He "inspires gratitude" and "praise" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 116). Herein, in the complexity of its formation and functionality, the biological human form is proof of Allah's Mercy and Power, alongside the human ability to praise and thank Him for it.

The ability to praise and be grateful to Allah for His Mercy and as a sign of His Mercy is further outlined in the first supplication of the *Sahifah*. In 'Praise of God' Al-Sajjad states that had Allah not given humanity the ability to praise and thank him: "they would have left the bounds of humanity for that of beastliness and become as He has described in the firm text of His Book ... as the cattle" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 17). The direct reference to 25:46, which depicts those "astray" from thankfulness and praising Allah as "cattle" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 17), serves as a proof-text outlining the God-given ability to praise and thank Him as a Mercy upon humanity. As the Quran and the *Sahifah* outline, Allah does

¹¹¹ Table 5(a).

not need praise and thanksgiving. Instead, humanity needs such engagement and communication with Allah to actualize and make accessible their createdness.

The Merciful Provider

Apart from using proof texts for Allah's Merciful role as The Creator, the *Sahifah* also references portions of the Quran as proof of Allah's Merciful role as the Provider (*Ar-Raziq*), The Sustainer (*Al-Muqet*) and The Bestower of Bounty (*Al-Wahab*)¹¹². In 'His supplication when provision was stinted' Al-Sajjad emphasizes Allah's promise of sustenance in the Quran by saying:

“Let Thy clear promise in Thy revelation which Thou hast followed in Thy Book
with Thy oath cut off our worry about the provision for which Thou hast made
Thyself responsible and sever our occupation with everything whose sufficiency
Thou hast guaranteed” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 102).

Such an overt emphasis on Allah's promises is not to remind Allah of His responsibilities per se, but rather to reassure and remind uncertain, fearful believers of Allah's guarantees regarding their subsistence. It is also about Allah's Divine Mercy as The Compassionate (*Al-Rahman*) and The Merciful (*Al-Rahim*)¹¹³. *Al-Rahman*, as per The Study Quran, "connotes the Loving-Mercy by which God brings forth existence. *Al-Rahim* indicates the blessings of nourishment (*rizq*) by which God sustains each particular existent thing” (Nasr, The Study Quran: A New Translation and Commentary, 60). Another example of Allah's Mercy and Compassion for believers is mentioned in 'His supplication in bidding farewell to the month of Ramadan', wherein Al-Sajjad directly quotes Quranic verse 2:224

¹¹² Table 5(a).

¹¹³ Table 5(a).

as a proof-text of Allah multiplying good deeds. The *Sahifah* talks about the Quranic concept of making transactions with Allah in the form of deeds:

“Thou hast said, *who is he that will lend to God a good loan, and He will multiply it for him manifold?* And Thou hast sent down in the Quran similar verses on the multiplying of good deeds” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 150).

In these verses of the *Sahifah* and the Quran, Allah's Benevolence, Generosity and Bounty towards those who do good are emphasized as a sign of His special Mercy towards believers. This special Mercy towards believers is highlighted in 33:43; "And He is Merciful unto the believers".

The Merciful Forgiver

Another form of Allah's Mercy - which Al-Sajjad employs Quranic verses as proof-texts for – is His Forgiveness (*Al-Ghafoor*) and Pardon (*Al-Ghaffar*) in response to human repentance (*tawbah*). In 'His supplication for bidding farewell to the month of Ramadan' verse 10, the *Sahifah* describes "repentance" as "a door to [Allah's] pardon" which Allah himself "opened for [His] servants" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 149). Al-Sajjad paints a cosmic image of the door of repentance with references to Quranic verses:

“Thou hast placed upon that door a pointer from Thy revelation, lest they stray from it: Thou hast said (blessed are Thy names): *Repent toward God with unswerving repentance! It may be that Thy Lord will acquit of you of your evil deeds and will admit you into the gardens beneath which rivers flow* (66:8)” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 149).

Herein, Revelation is used as proof of Allah's Mercy to offer hope to those whose ill deeds and misgivings may plunge them into despair of never recovering from them. For devout believers or those whose heedlessness is lessening, these verses of the *Sahifah* offer hope of achieving Allah's pleasure through repentance. It also sheds light on the ability of the human condition to overcome its lower self through Allah's Pardon. Similarly 'His

supplication in Fear" describes how Al-Sajjad himself discovered evidence of Allah's Compassionate capacity for Forgiveness in the Quran and through the process of revelation. The second verse of the supplication states:

“O God, I found in the Book which Thou sent down and through which Thou gave good news to Thy servants, that Thou said, *O, My servants who have been prodigal against yourselves, do not despair of God’s mercy, surely God forgives all sins* (39:53)” (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 198).

Since this supplication addresses the human condition of fear, Al-Sajjad uses portions of the Quran to alleviate these fears. Despite their overwhelming sins, believers are reassured of Allah's overwhelming Forgiveness and Mercy. Allah's Nature is depicted as All-Powerful (*Al-Muqtadir*)¹¹⁴ in the Quran and the *Sahifah*, making His Mercy Powerful enough to release believers from their fears, anxieties, and uncertainties. Moreover, believers are reminded that no matter how prodigal they have been, Allah's Expansive Forgiveness is greater than the quality and quantity of human sins, especially their despair. In 'His supplication in mentioning and asking for repentance', Al-Sajjad alludes to the Quranic verses 9:104, 42:25 and 2:222, which not only assure believers about Allah's "acceptest repentance" but also that He "lovest the repenters" (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 107). The *Sahifah* states in the fifteenth verse of the supplication:

Though hast said, my God, in the firm text of Thy Book, that Thou acceptest repentance from Thy servants, and pardonest evil deeds, and lovest the repenters, so accept my repentance as Thou hast promised, pardon my evil deeds as Thou hast guaranteed, and make obligatory towards me Thy love as Thou hast stipulated (Ali ibn al-Husayn, 107).

The *Sahifah* assures believers of Allah's acceptance, pardon, and love in these verses. Moreover, these verses from the Quran and the *Sahifah* depict forgiveness as that which

¹¹⁴ Table 5(a).

Allah's Love accompanies. Al-Sajjad inspires believers to aspire for Allah's Mercy, Forgiveness and Love and outlines the unique bilateral relationship between every creature and Allah. At the same time, this relationship depicts sinning and needing repentance as a unilateral human occupation. The ability to show Mercy and Forgiveness is solely Allah's prerogative – the love between them is shown as mutual. Although Allah is considered the Source of all Love, humanity's ability to love Allah is a lesser love – it is something both creation and the Divine partake in.

Hence, by analysing how the Quran is mentioned and portrayed in the *Sahifah*, we can see how the Quran is considered a manifestation of Allah's Mercy. The Quran presents many qualities, attributes and functions in light of the Merciful *Asma al-Husna wal Sifat*. The thematic concern and correspondence of Allah's overwhelming Mercy in both the *Sahifah* and the Quran are made evident in light of the *Sahifah's* relation to the Quran – as its sister.

Conclusion

The last section demonstrates the mosaic of Quranic verses with which Al-Sajjad decorates his supplications. He speaks about the Quran through a wide range of attributes, motifs, imagery and references – lending the *Sahifah* a sense of sensory, auditory, spiritual and metaphysical overload of concepts pieced together. This research has aimed to show the mosaic of the *Sahifah* by zooming into the Quranic pieces and then zooming out to see the plethora of doctrines, images, motifs and ideas that complement, elaborate upon, and help visualize the place of the Quran as the word of Allah, in the human soul.

The *Sahifah* can be seen as a piece of Islamic art that depicts the flux of the dynamic fragments of the human soul. The research has focused on the Quran due to its importance in the *Sahifah* and Al-Sajjad's portrayal of it as a Mercy. Hence, the paper shows how, alongside echoing the Quran's overwhelming Mercy, Al-Sajjad also regards the Quran as a Mercy in light of its various *Jamali Asmt al-Husna wal-Siffat*. Moreover, Al-Sajjad presents and engages with the Quran's qualities, functions and attributions as a Merciful companion and guide for believers in the temporal world, the hereafter and the Day of Judgement.

The most prevalent way the *Sahifah* and the Quran describe Allah is in light of The Divine Unity of His Being through the *Asma al-Husna wal-Siffat*. The *Sahifah* acts as a spiritual exercise and instructional manual on aligning different psycho-spiritual, socio-political and economic states with different aspects of Divine Nature. Moreover, it helps believers actualize a concrete relationship of love, mercy and worship with a Transcendental, Sublime Lord. Instead of creating distance with fear and awe, Al-Sajjad nurtures proximity through confessions, repentance and imploring.

One of the main focuses of this research is to demonstrate the overwhelming Mercy of Divine Nature in the *Sahifah* through the Quran. Al-Sajjad despairs the shortcomings of the human condition but never of Allah's Mercy. Allah's depiction in the *Sahifah* aligns with the notion that 'Allah's Mercy supersedes His Wrath'. Al-Sajjad establishes this premise in not a few or most of his supplications but *all* of them. This is evident in the fact that Allah's Mercy, Forgiveness, Kindness, Love and other *Jamali* attributes are mentioned and elaborated upon, superseding His Wrath, Vengeance, Punishment and Loathing. His Wrath is also only spoken of with His Mercy. The *Sahifah* also engages with Allah's *Jalal*, like His Power, Might, Sovereignty and Majesty as Merciful – interlacing *Jalal* and *Jamal* to depict a Powerfully Merciful and Mercifully Powerful Allah.

Al-Sajjad wraps the *Sahifah* in the circumference of the Shariah, outlining Islamic rituals and prescribing what is permissible and what is not. All the while, he explores the infinite radii of *turaq* leading to the origin of Allah's Ultimate Reality, where images of an All-Merciful, All-Powerful, Ever-Forgiving and Ever-Loving Allah blend seamlessly into one another.

Since Al-Sajjad is believed to understand the innermost meaning of the Quran as per the Shi'ite *walayah* doctrine, his placement and application of Quranic verses throughout the *Sahifah* cannot be underestimated. Al-Sajjad lays down the blueprint of knowing, loving and worshipping Allah as one of the select few who most intimately understand Divine Nature and the Divine Word. Through the mosaic of Al-Sajjad's soul, believers can access the Mosaic of The Ultimate Reality, just as through the *Sahifah*, believers can access the innermost Reality of the Quran.

Al-Sajjad was known for his piety and devotion in worship – and the *Sahifah* is a necessary mystical treatise for Shi'ite believers, just as supplication is necessary to worship. Al-Sajjad played a monumental role in shaping spiritual attitudes for over 1400 years through his conversations with Allah, in which he quotes Allah to Allah, enlightening and enriching the collective and individual imagination. The tragedy of Karbala is unarguably one of, if not the most, influential event in Al-Sajjad's psycho-spiritual and socio-political life. Indeed, these traumas shaped his spiritual imagination and religiosity, just as Karbala has shaped the spirituality and religiosity of millions of Shi'a Muslims for over 1400 years. Since Al-Sajjad is intricately associated with the aftermath of Karbala, often Shi'a Muslims also associate the *Sahifah* as a creative spiritual product of the tragedy.

Conclusively, this paper has used various quantitative and qualitative analyses to explore the relationship and correspondence between the *Sahifah* and the Quran. Though the research has briefly focused on only three aspects of this relationship, there are many more. Similarly, the last two sections do not do justice to the overwhelming mercy in the *Sahifah* due to their brevity. However, the data extracted from the *Sahifah* in Appendix A. opens the way for more thorough research. While the paper has analyzed the *Sahifah* through resources available in modern Western scholarship, it has yet to explore Arabic and Persian commentaries which show how the *Sahifah* has been traditionally seen. By studying these commentaries, one would better understand how Shi'a Muslims have engaged with and understood the *Sahifah* for over 1400 years. Further research on the *Sahifah* and its commentaries – yet to be translated into English – is a dire necessity for scholarship on Shi'a mysticism. Hopefully, this research can be a foundation for a more thorough

understanding of the *Sahifah al-Sajjadiyyah* in the Shi'ite intellectual and mystical traditions.

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Appendix A

Table 1 – Thematic categorization of supplication titles in the *Sahifah*

Supplication titles		
Thematic Concern	Frequency	Supplication Number
Allah's Nature	3	1, 55, 56
Angels	1	3
Holy Prophet and Household	4	2, 4, 57, 58
Positive psycho-spiritual states	12	18, 37,39,72,74,75,76,77
Negative psycho-spiritual states	18	8.9.10.12.16.17.28.31.34.38.50.51.53.59.61.69.70.71.79
Social human ailment	4	14,30,34,49
Personal human ailment	8	7.15.21.22.29.41.54.60
Cosmic/ natural events	6	6,19,32,36,40,43
Ritual events	13	42,44,45,46,47,48,62,63,64,65,66,67,68
Socio-personal relations	6	5,24,25,26,27,35
Personal positive personal aspirations	7	11,13,20,23,30,73,78

Table 2 – First verse of each supplication in the *Sahifah*

Beginning Verses		
Thematic Concern	Frequency	Supplication Number
Begin with Bismillah (In the Name of Allah's Mercy and Compassion)	16	82, 81, 80,79, 78, 77, 74, 73, 72, 71, 70, 69
Praise be to God (Alhamdillah)	15	67, 66, 65, 64, 63, 56, 44, 35, 34, 15, 18, 6,

Illahi (My God)	12	81,80,79,78,77,74,73,70,69,51,49, 59
Bless the Holy Prophet and His Household	14	41,40,39,30,23,24,26,9,57, 4 (Adam 58)
Nature/ Cosmos	6	48,43,19,3,42, 36
Might	3	5,10,32
Mercy	3	16,46,60
Allah as The Helpful	4	7,21,13,54
Remembering God	1	11
Seeking refuge in God	2	8, 17
The Knower	4	14,31,33,52
The Giver	1	45
The Creator	1	50
Gratitude	1	37
Forgiveness	1	38
Human condition related	6	,(helplessness53),(The Allah tries 29), (helplessness 22) (chi 25),(sincerity 28), (disobedience 12)
Glory be to God	1	55

Table 3 – Thematic categorization of the last verse of each supplication in the *Sahifah*

Concluding verses		
Thematic Concern	Frequency	Supplication Number
Most Merciful of the Merciful	23	81, 80, 79, 78,77,76,75,74,73,72,49,48,32,24,8,5,70,69,68,66,51,33,34
Human-centric	2	(human speech, 29), (the godfearing,4)

The Responder	1	11
Lord of the Worlds	6	53,39,41,26,17,12
The One	1	28
The Mighty	8	59,55,46,44,31,23,21,7
The Holy Prophet and his household	8	60,54,47,42,43,13,18,6
Praise Be to Allah	2	22,1
Negative (human condition)	3	Mufasideen 40, fire 25, punishment 9
Allah's Generosity	7	82,56,52,37,30,2,3
The-All Compassionate	2	62,50
The Forgiver	2	63,38
Patron of Beneficence	1	64
The Gentle	1	65
Powerful over all things(<i>ends in Quranic verse</i>)	5	5,7,16,19, 20
Unto thee is homecoming (Ar-Rahman Tawab) (<i>ends in Quranic verse</i>)	1	36
Thou art Mighty and Wise (<i>ends in Quranic verse</i>)	1	67
Every soul shall pay what the earned (<i>ends in Quranic verse</i>)	1	71

Table 4 – Quranic verses in the *Sahifah*

No.	Verse	Frequency References	Frequency Allusions	Supplication no.
1.	3:26	14	N/A	6r, 12r, 16r, 19r, 21r, 31r, 32r, 33r, 45a, 46r, 49r, 57r, 75r,

2.	40:60	5	N/A	12r, 25r, 31r, 45r, 58r,
3.	2:186	3	N/A	12r, 25r, 47r,
4.	7:151	3	N/A	24r, 65r, 66r
5.	12:53	3	1	9r, 64r, 70r,
6.	25:70	3	N/A	2r, 24r, 32r
7.	66:8	3	N/A	45r, 47r, 69r,
8.	2:128	2	N/A	31r, 50r
9.	2:185	2	N/A	42r, 44r,
	2:201	2	N/A	20r, 25r
10.	18:49	2	N/A	47r, 50r,
11.	27:62	2	1	10r, 14r, 58a
12.	37:173	2	N/A	47r, 64r,
13.	42:25	2	N/A	31r, 31r, 45a
14.	53:31	2	N/A	1r, 6r
15.	97:3	2	N/A	45r, 45r,
16.	112:1	3	N/A	35r, 47r, 54r,
17.	112:2	3	N/A	35r, 47r, 54r,

18.	112:3	3	N/A	35r, 47r, 54r,
19.	112:4	3	N/A	35r, 47r, 54r,
20.	2:222	1	1	31r, 38a, 45a,
21.	2:286	1	1	1r, 1a
22.	2:152	1	1	45r, 81a,
23.	3:106	1	1	1r, 42a
24.	4:174	N/A	2	N/A
25.	5:35	1	1	42r, 47a,
26.	5:48	N/A	2	42a,
27.	7:17	1	1	6a, 32r,
28.	7:54	1	1	65a,
29.	11:56	2	N/A	21r, 23r
30.	13:31	N/A	2	58a, 67a
31.	17:13	1	1	42a, 50r
32.	1:2	1	N/A	47r,
33.	2:16	N/A	1	47a,
34.	2:55	1	N/A	N/A
35.	2:129	1	N/A	67r

36.	2:143	1	N/A	42r
37.	2:197	N/A	1	21a
38.	2:216	1	N/A	N/A
39.	2:245	1	N/A	45r,
40.	2:285	1	N/A	36r
41.	3:4	1	N/A	42r
42.	3:8	1	N/A	66r
43.	3:25	1	N/A	71r,
44.	3:54	N/A	1	5a
45.	3:103	N/A	1	31a
46.	4:6	N/A	1	50a,
47.	4:40	N/A	1	37a
48.	4:59	N/A	1	34a
49.	4:108	N/A	1	47a,
50.	4:110	N/A	1	12a
51.	4:174	N/A	1	42a
52.	6:96	N/A	1	6a
53.	6:115	1	N/A	47r,

54.	6:122	1	N/A	22r
55.	6:160	1	N/A	45r,
56.	7:14	1	N/A	32r,
57.	7:16	1	N/A	32r,
58.	7:18	1	N/A	32r
59.	7:51	N/A	1	67a
60.	7:156	1	N/A	58r,
61.	7:182	N/A	1	47a,
62.	8:6	N/A	1	42a
63.	8:57	1	N/A	27r,
64.	8:68	N/A	1	54a
65.	9:33	N/A	1	2a
66.	9:100	1	N/A	47r,
67.	9:104	1	N/A	31r, 45a,
68.	10:4	N/A	1	20a,
69.	10:25	1	N/A	47r,
70.	10:57	1	N/A	42r
71.	10:61	1	N/A	47r,

72.	10:62	1	N/A	64r,
73.	10:67	1	N/A	6r,
74.	10:64	N/A	2	58a, 67a
75.	11:20	N/A	1	1a,
76.	11:40	N/A	1	1a
77.	11:80	N/A	1	82a
78.	12:2	N/A	1	42a
79.	13:13	N/A	1	27a
80.	13:24	1	N/A	3r
81.	13:28	N/A	1	81a,
82.	14:1	1	N/A	N/A
83.	14:7	1	N/A	45r,
84.	14:13	N/A	1	14a
85.	14:33	1	N/A	1r,
86.	15:21	1	N/A	47r,
87.	15:22	1	N/A	47r,
88.	15:23	1	N/A	47r,
89.	15:36	1	N/A	32r

90.	15:37	1	N/A	32r
91.	15:38	1	N/A	32r
92.	15:39	1	N/A	32r
93.	15:40	1	N/A	32r
94.	15:41	1	N/A	32r
95.	15:42	1	N/A	32r
96.	15:43	1	N/A	32r
97.	15:47	N/A	1	47a,
98.	15:88	N/A	1	20a,
99.	15:94	N/A	1	47a,
100.	16:22	1	N/A	N/A
101.	16:85	1	N/A	3r
102.	17:7	N/A	1	67a
103.	17:12	1	N/A	6r
104.	17:16	N/A	1	47a, 72a,
105.	17:80	N/A	1	47a,
106.	17:82	1	N/A	42r
107.	17:85	1	N/A	3r

108.	18:26	N/A	1	N/A
109.	18:103	N/A	1	47a,
110.	18:104	N/A	1	47a,
111.	18:109	N/A	1	47a,
112.	19:75	N/A	1	47a,
113.	20:6	1	N/A	55r,
114.	20:8	1	N/A	51r
115.	20:31	1	N/A	47r,
116.	20:111	N/A	1	63r
117.	20:113	N/A	1	42a
118.	20:130	N/A	1	42a
119.	22:3	1	N/A	23r
120.	22:78	1	N/A	66r
121.	23:11	1	N/A	44r,
122.	23:12	1	N/A	32r
123.	23:13	1	N/A	32r
124.	23:14	1	N/A	32r
125.	23:54	1	N/A	47r,

126.	23:60	1	N/A	44r,
127.	23:61	1	N/A	44r,
128.	25:1	1	N/A	42r
129.	25:2	1	N/A	47r,
130.	25:46	1	N/A	1r,
131.	25:47	1	N/A	65r
132.	25:69	1	N/A	32r
133.	25:68	1	N/A	32r
134.	26:84	1	N/A	N/A
135.	26:215	N/A	1	20a,
136.	28:35	N/A	1	47a,
137.	28:50	N/A	1	8a
138.	29:57	N/A	1	52a
139.	29:69	N/A	1	75a
140.	30:54	N/A	1	9a
141.	31:20	1	N/A	1r,
142.	32:5	N/A	1	47a,
143.	32:7	1	N/A	32r

144.	33:33	1	N/A	47r,
145.	33:39	N/A	1	50a,
146.	33:41	N/A	1	81a,
147.	33:52	1	N/A	47r,
148.	34:3	N/A	1	50a,
149.	35:15	1	N/A	13r
150.	35:28	N/A	1	52a,
151.	35:29	1	N/A	4r
152.	36:39	N/A	1	43a
153.	37:8	N/A	1	55a
154.	38:26	N/A	1	8a
155.	38:69	N/A	1	55a
156.	38:79	1	N/A	32r
157.	38:80	1	N/A	32r
158.	38:81	1	N/A	32r
159.	38:82	1	N/A	32r
160.	38:84	1	N/A	32r
161.	38:85	1	N/A	32r

162.	38:86	1	N/A	32r
163.	39:23	N/A	1	42a
164.	39:53	1	N/A	50r
165.	40:7	1	N/A	16r,
166.	40:54	N/A	1	1a,
167.	41:3	1	N/A	42r
168.	41:54	1	N/A	47r,
169.	42:11	1	N/A	47r,
170.	43:11	N/A	1	48a, 59a
171.	44:41	1	N/A	1r,
172.	45:13	1	N/A	1r
173.	45:21	1	N/A	1r,
174.	45:22	1	N/A	24r
175.	45:34	N/A	1	67a
176.	47:31	N/A	1	6a
177.	51:22	N/A	1	29r
178.	51:23	1	N/A	29r
179.	66:6	1	N/A	3r

180.	69:17	1	N/A	3r,
181.	69:36	1	N/A	3r
182.	56:88	1	N/A	47r,
183.	56:89	1	N/A	47r,
184.	57:9	1	N/A	42r
185.	57:25	1	N/A	42r
186.	58:22	1	N/A	64r,
187.	59:10	1	N/A	4r
188.	59:16	1	N/A	32r
189.	59:21	1	N/A	42a
190.	61:9	N/A	1	2a
191.	65:11	1	N/A	42r
192.	70:19	N/A	1	70a,
193.	70:20	N/A	1	70a,
194.	70:21	N/A	1	70a,
195.	72:28	1	N/A	47r,
196.	74:56	1	N/A	12r,
197.	75:7	1	N/A	1r,

198.	75:26	1	N/A	42r
199.	75:27	1	N/A	42r
200.	75:56	1	N/A	47r,
201.	76:23	1	N/A	42r
202.	77:20	1	N/A	9r
203.	78:21	N/A	1	20a,
204.	78:22	N/A	1	20a,
205.	78:23	N/A	1	20a,
206.	79:6	1	N/A	47r,
207.	79:7	1	N/A	47r,
208.	79:8	1	N/A	47r,
209.	79:9	1	N/A	47r,
210.	79:10	1	N/A	47r,
211.	79:11	1	N/A	47r,
212.	79:12	1	N/A	47r,
213.	80:16	1	N/A	3r
214.	80:20	N/A	1	47a,
215.	81:21	1	N/A	N/A

216.	83:4	N/A	1	70a,
217.	83:18	N/A	1	1a
218.	83:19	N/A	1	1a
219.	83:20	1	N/A	1r
220.	83:21	1	N/A	1r,
221.	86:9	1	N/A	47r,
222.	86:15	N/A	1	N/A
223.	87:2	N/A	1	65a,
224.	89:15	N/A	1	1a
225.	89:28	N/A	1	80a,
226.	97:4	1	N/A	44r,
227.	97:5	1	N/A	44r,
228.	108:1	N/A	1	42a
229.	113:1	1	N/A	54r,
230.	113:2	1	N/A	54r,
231.	113:3	1	N/A	54r,
232.	113:4	1	N/A	54r,
233.	113:5	1	N/A	54r,

234.	114:1	1	N/A	42r, 54r,
235.	114:2	1	N/A	54r,
236.	114:3	1	N/A	54r,
237.	114:4	1	N/A	54r,
238.	114:5	1	N/A	54r,
239.	114:6	1	N/A	54r,
240.	21:23	1	1	1r, 49a
241.	16:12	1	N/A	1r
242.	50:21	1	1	3r, 42a
243.	86:15	N/A	1	5a
244.	2:207	1	N/A	6r
245.	18:28	N/A	1	8a
246.	2:264	1	N/A	20r
247.	7:15	1	N/A	32r
248.	38:83	1	N/A	32r
249.	2:261	1	N/A	45r
250.	17:14	1	N/A	50r
251.	2:255	1	N/A	54r

252.	12:64	1	N/A	62r
253.	9:67	N/A	1	67a
254.	9:93	N/A	1	70a
255.	50:22a	N/A	1	80a
256.	7:186	1	N/A	47r
257.	9:78	1	N/A	55r
258.	Total reference and Allusion 319	Total references=	Total allusions=	

Table 5(a) – Allah’s Nature in Quranic verses referenced in the <i>Sahifah</i>				
	Name	Jamali/	Frequency Sahifah	Verses
1.	Creator, The Maker Al Khaliq	Jamali	9	77:20, 87:2, 113:2, 23:1 23:14, 25:2, 30:54, 32:7 45:22,
2.	Allah’s Help		1	22:78
3.	As Sami - All Seeing	Jamali	3	18:26, 33:52, 41:11
4.	All Compassionate – Ar Raheem	Jamali	2	19:75, 25:60
5.	All Merciful – Ar Rahman	Jamali	16	59:10, 7:151, 12:53, 25: 2:128, 2:286, 11:56, 4:1 7:156, 9:104, 10:57, 17: 39:53, 40:7, 57:9, 12:64
6.	Al Ghaffar – The Forgiver	Jamali	9	12:53, 25:70, 42:25, 2:2 4:110, 35:28, 39:53, 40: 74:56,
7.	Responder – Al Mujeeb	Jamali	3	40:60, 2:186, 27:62
8.	Praiseworthy	Jalali	2	14:1, 1:2
9.	The Kind – Al Karim	Jamali	2	57:9, 59:10
10	All Knowing - Al Alim	Jamali	10	42:25, 6:96, 6:115, 10:6 17:85, 30:54, 34:3, 2:26 2:255, 9:78
11	Lord/ Master – Al Malik	Jalali	13	3:26, 53:31, 2:286, 13:3 1:2, 20:6, 22:78, 25:2, 3 59:16, 97:4, 14:2, 114:3 21:23
12	All Powerful - Al Qadir	Jalali	3	3:26, 30:54, 21:23
13	All Hearing - Al Baseer	Jamali/	3	6:115, 18:26, 42:11

14	Allah as Refugee		2	113:1, 114:1
15	The Guide – Al Hadi	Jalali	15	40:54, 57:29, 61:9, 2:18, 4:174, 5:48, 2:143, 3:8, 3:103, 6:122, 7:182, 10:10:57, 32:5, 39:23,
16	The Protector	Jamali	2	2:201, 18:26
17	Al Haq – The Truth	Jalali	2	6:115, 38:84
18	The Loving – Al Wadood	Jamali	2	2:222
19	The Inheritor – Al Waris	Jamali	1	15:23
20	The Withholder – Al-Qabid	Jalali	1	2:245
21	The Living/ Self Subsisting - Al-Qayyum	Jamali/	2	20:111, 2:255
22	The Extender – Al-Basit	Jalali	1	2:245
23	All Encompassing – Al-Waasi	Jamali	5	4:108, 40:7, 41:54, 72:2, 2:261
24	The Bestower –Al- Muiz	Jalali	2	3:8, 108:1
25	Reckoner – Al-Haseeb	Jamali	2	4:6, 33:39
26	Unique – Al-Ahad	Jalali	3	112:3, 112:4, 25:2
27	The Eternal - As Samad	Jalali	1	112:2,
28	The One – Al Wahid	Jalali	5	112:1, 16:22, 120:8, 25:2:255
29	The Relenting – At Tawab	Jalali	2	2:128, 9:104,
30	The Just - Al-Adil	Jamali	3	18:49, 4:40, 6:115
31	The Al Mighty - Al-Aziz	Jamali	7	57:29, 2:129, 3:4, 6:96, 35:28, 33:82,
32	The All Wise – Al-Hakeem	Jalali	2	2:129, 3:54
33	The Magnificent – Al-Azeem	Jamali	1	2:255
34	The Exalted – Al-Ali	Jalali	1	2:255
35	Vengeance		1	3:4

36	Allah's wrath/ punishment		11	2:201, 2:55, 7:156, 8:68 10:4, 11:20, 14:7, 14:13 16:85, 17:7, 17:16
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Table 5(b) – Human Nature in Quranic verses quoted in the *Sahifah*

Human Nature in Quranic verses quoted in the <i>Sahifah</i>		
Thematic concern	Frequency in <i>Sahifah</i>	Quranic verses
disbelievers	1	86:15
Disobedient	3	3:106, 7:18, 15:88
Anxious	2	70:20, 70:19
Pious	4	83:18, 83:19, 83:21, 83:20
Righteous	3	25:70, 45:21, 65:11
Sincere	2	15:40, 38:83
Virtuous	4	53:31, 9:100, 17:7, 29:69
Relationship between Allah and humans	8	2:286, 3:106, 2:152, 6:160, 9:3 80:20, 81:21, 89:15
Those astray	9	2:16, 4:108, 18:103, 18:104, 21: 28:50, 39:23, 18:28, 7:186
Those deluded	2	7:51, 7:186
Arrogance/ Arrogant	4	40:60, 7:54, 16:22, 2:264
Those who repent	3	42:25, 12:222, 9:104
Those from Satan's party	2	22:3, 38:85
Those in distress	1	27:62
The patient ones	2	13:34, 18:28
Purified/ those who purify	2	2:222, 33:33
Those who strive for God	5	5:48, 22:78, 29:69, 18:28, 2:26
Rebellious	1	7:186

Hypocrites	1	9:67
Muslim Ummah	1	4:6

Table 5(c) – Miscellaneous themes in Quranic verses quoted in the *Sahifah*

Other themes in Quranic verses quoted in the <i>Sahifah</i>		
Thematic concern	Frequencies in the <i>Sahifah</i>	Quranic verses
Qiyaamah	18	86:9, 3:106, 17:13, 3:25, 4:59, 7:14, 7:51, 15:38, 20:111, 38:81, 44:41, 48:22, 79:6, 79:8, 83:4, 2:264, 17:14
Calamity	1	13:31
Human hearts	11	3:8, 3:103, 15:47, 23:60, 58:22, 79:8, 79:10, 79:11, 79:12, 9:93
Prophetic prayer	9	7:151, 2:128, 3:54, 11:40, 11:80, 17:80, 2:26:84, 12:64
Holy Prophet	12	2:143, 2:285, 4:59, 9:13, 15:94, 22:78, 26:33:33, 38:36, 59:21, 61:9,
Rituals/ Shariah Juncture	8	2:185, 2:222, 2:97, 22:78, 23:60, 25:68, 33:52
Cosmos / Nature	14	13:13, 14:33, 5:21, 15:22, 6:96, 10:67, 14:33, 17:12, 20:130, 25:47, 113:1, 16:12
Directive	3	66:8, 2:216, 20:13
Hellfire	9	2:201, 7:18, 38:85, 40:7, 66:6, 69:36, 78:78:22, 78:23
Allah's conversation with Satan	15	7:54, 7:14, 7:16, 7:18, 15:36, 15:37, 15:39, 15:41, 15:42, 38:80, 38:81, 38:82, 38:83
Evil	8	12:53, 4:110, 45:21, 70:20, 113:2, 113:3, 113:4, 113:5
Islamic Events	5	37:173, 96:3, 8:6, 8:57, 97:4

Quran	27	25:1, 31:20, 34:3, 35:29, 39:23, 2:185, 18:5:48, 13:31, 18:49, 2:129, 2:143, 2:285, 3:4:174, 6:115, 10:57, 10:61, 12:2, 14:1, 17:18:109, 20:113, 41:3, 57:25, 59:21, 76:23
Prophetic Stories	6	11:56, 18:26, 28:35, 33:39, 57:25, 58:22
“No soul shall be tasked beyond its capacity”	2	2:280, 23:61,
Friends of God	2	10:62, 10:64
Angels	4	69:17, 72:28, 80:16, 16:12
Death	1	50:22

Table 6 – Frequency of merciful and wrathful motifs/imagery s of Allah

Motif/Imagery	Frequency	Motif/Imagery	Frequency
Wrath	19	Mercy / Merciful	226
Vengeance	25	Generous/ Generosity	81
Chastisement	17	Munificent/ Munificence	25
Disgrace	6	Praise/Praiseworthy	113
Hell	3	Forgiver/Forgiveness	85
Hellfire	2	Refugee	46
Loathing	1	Beauty/natures beauty/human beauty	15/1/1
		Compassion/ Compassionate	25
		Peace/ peaceful	4
		Giver/	143
		Giver of gifts	21
		Gentle/ gentleness	21
		Clement/ clemency	29
		Forbearer/ forbearance	13

		Bountiful/ Bounty	92
		responder	32
		love/ loving/ lover	62
		Pardon/ pardoner	85
		Friend/ friendship	15/17
		Patient/ patience	6
		Kind/ kindness	82
		Benefactor/ benefaction	57
		Good / goodness	128